

Wikipedia:Manual of Style



This guideline is a part of the English Wikipedia's Manual of Style.

Editors should generally follow it, though it is best treated with common sense, and exceptions may apply. *Substantive* edits to this page should reflect consensus.

This **Manual of Style** (MoS or MOS) is the style manual for all English Wikipedia articles.^[a] This primary page is supported by further detailed subpages, which may be cross-referenced here and are listed at Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Contents. If any contradiction arises, this page has precedence.^[b]

Editors should write articles using straightforward, succinct, and easily understood language. Editors should structure articles with consistent, reader-friendly layouts and formatting.

Where more than one style or format is acceptable under the MoS, one should be used consistently within an article and should not be changed without good reason. Edit warring over stylistic choices is unacceptable.^[c] New content added to this page should directly address a persistently recurring style issue.

Retaining existing styles

"MOS:VAR" redirects here. For retention of an article's established national English variety, see § National varieties of English. For a list of more specific related rules, see WP:VARs.

Sometimes the MoS provides more than one acceptable style or gives no specific guidance. When either of two styles is acceptable it is generally considered inappropriate for a Wikipedia editor to change from one style to another unless there is some substantial reason for the change.^[d]

Edit warring over style, or enforcing optional style in a bot-like fashion without prior consensus, is disruptive and is never acceptable.^{[c][e]}

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Unjustified changes from one acceptable, consistently applied style in an article to a different style may generally be reverted. Seek opportunities for commonality to avoid disputes over style.

If you believe an alternative style would be more appropriate for a particular article, seek consensus by discussing this at the article's talk page or – if it raises an issue of more general application or with the MoS itself – at Wikipedia talk:Manual of Style. If a discussion does not result in consensus for the change at the article, continue to use the already-established style there. If discussion fails to reach a consensus regarding which of two or more competing styles to use at all, then default to the style that was used in the first post-stub version of the article in which one of the applicable styles appeared. (This fall-back position does not give unchallengeable primacy to that particular style during consensus discussion, nor give the editor who imposed that earliest style any more say in the discussion.)

Article titles, sections, and headings

Article titles

Main page: Wikipedia:Article titles

For titles which coincide with a work's title, see Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Titles of works.

A title should be a recognizable name or description of the topic, balancing the criteria of being natural, sufficiently precise, concise, and consistent with those of related articles.

For formatting guidance see the Wikipedia:Article titles § Article title format section, noting the following:

- Capitalize the initial letter (except in rare cases, such as **eBay**), but otherwise follow sentence case^[f] (**Funding of UNESCO projects**), not title case (**Funding of UNESCO Projects**), except where title case would be used in ordinary prose. See Wikipedia:Naming conventions (capitalization).
- To italicize, add `{{italic title}}` near the top of the article. To italicize only part of the title, include the `|string=` parameter with the specific text to be italicized. Use of italics should conform to Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Text formatting § Italic type.
- Do not use articles (*a*, *an*, or *the*) as the first word (**Economy of the Second Empire**, not **The economy of the Second Empire**), unless it is an inseparable part of a name (**The Hague**) or of the title of a work (***A Clockwork Orange***, ***The Simpsons***).
- Normally use nouns or noun phrases: **Early life**, not **In early life**.^[g]

See also:

Naming conventions (geographic names)

• *WikiProject style advice*

Science and technology

Chemistry • Computer science •

Mathematics • Medicine • Taxonomy •

See also: *WikiProject style advice*

Other

Blazons • Cue sports (Snooker) • Islam •

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Trademarks •

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Related guidelines

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Understandability

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- The final character should not be punctuation unless it is an inseparable part of a name ([Saint-Louis-du-Ha! Ha!](#), *[Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?](#)*) or an abbreviation ([Inverness City F.C.](#)), or when a closing round bracket or quotation mark is required (*[John Palmer \(1814 schooner\)](#)*).
- Whenever quotation marks or apostrophe-like variants appear ([Ge`ez](#)), add a [redirect](#) for the same title using apostrophes ([Ge'ez](#)).^[h]

Subject both to the above and to [Wikipedia:Article titles](#), the rest of the MoS, particularly [§ Punctuation](#), applies also to the title.

Section organization

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Layout](#)

An article's content should begin with an introductory [lead section](#) – a concise summary of the article – which is never divided into sections (see [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Lead section](#)). The remainder of the article is typically divided into [sections](#).

[Infoboxes](#), images, and other related content in the lead section must be right-aligned.

Certain standardized [templates](#) and [wikitext](#) that are not sections go at the very top of the article, before the content of the lead section, and in the following order:

- A [short description](#), with the `{{Short description}}` template
- A [disambiguation hatnote](#), most of the time with the `{{Hatnote}}` template (see also [Wikipedia:Hatnote § Hatnote templates](#))
- No-output templates that indicate the article's established date format and English-language variety, if any (e.g., `{{Use dmy dates}}`, `{{Use Canadian English}}`)
- Banner-type maintenance templates, [Dispute](#) and [Cleanup](#) templates for article-wide issues that have been flagged (otherwise used at the top of a specific section, after any sectional hatnote such as `{{main}}`)
- An [infobox](#), which is optional (except in special cases like `{{Taxobox}}` and `{{Chembox}}`, or a variant thereof, at applicable articles); usually also includes the first image
- An introductory image, when an infobox is not used, or an additional image is desired for the lead section (for unusually long leads, a second image can be placed midway through the lead text)

In the [Vector 2022](#) skin, the [table of contents](#) is separate from the article content. In some older skins, a navigable table of contents appears automatically just after the lead if an article has at least four section headings.

If the topic of a section is covered in more detail in a dedicated article (see [Wikipedia:Summary style](#)), insert `{{main|Article name}}` or `{{further|Article name}}` immediately under the section heading.

As explained in detail in [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Layout § Standard appendices and footers](#), several kinds of material (mostly optional) may appear after the main body of the article, in the following order:

- Books or other works created by the subject of the article, under a section heading "Works", "Publications", "Discography", "Filmography", etc. as appropriate (avoid "Bibliography",

confusable with reference citations)

- Internal links to related English Wikipedia articles, with section heading "See also"
- Notes and references, with a section heading "Notes" or "References" (usually the latter), or a separate section for each in this order (see *Wikipedia:Citing sources*); avoid "Bibliography", confusable with the subject's works
- Relevant books, articles, or other publications that have not been used as sources; use the section heading "Further reading"; be highly selective, as *Wikipedia is not a bibliographic directory*
- Relevant and appropriate websites that have not been used as sources and do not appear in the earlier appendices, using the heading "External links", which may be made a subsection of "Further reading" (or such links can be integrated directly into the "Further reading" list instead); link templates for sister-project content also usually go at the top of this section when it is present (otherwise in the last section on the page)
- The following final items never take section headings:
 - Internal links organized into *navigational boxes*
 - *Authority control* metadata, if needed, using `{{Authority control}}` (distinguishes uses of the same name for two subjects, or multiple names for one subject)
 - *Categories*, which should be the very last material in the article's source code if there are no stub templates
 - *Stub templates*, if needed, which should follow the categories

Stand-alone list articles have some additional layout considerations.

Section headings

See also: *Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Accessibility § Headings*, *Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Layout § Order of article elements*, and *Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters § Section headings*

Section headings should generally follow the guidance for *article titles* above and be presented in *sentence case* (**Funding of UNESCO projects in developing countries**), not *title case* (**Funding of UNESCO Projects in Developing Countries**).^[f]

All headings must be on their own line, preceded by exactly one blank line, and followed by either one or no blank lines. Do not misuse *description list* markup (" ; ") to create *pseudo-headings*.

As a matter of consistent style, section headings should not:

- redundantly refer back to the subject of the article, e.g., **Early life**, not **Smith's early life** or **His early life**
- refer to a higher-level heading, unless doing so is shorter or clearer
- be numbered or lettered as an outline
- be phrased as a question, e.g., **Languages**, not **What languages are spoken?**
- use color or unusual fonts that may cause *accessibility problems*
- be wrapped in *markup*, such as bold and italics, which may break their display and cause other accessibility issues

Wikimarkup

For technical reasons, section headings should be unique within an article (so that *section links* work) and should not contain:

- links, even if only part of a heading is linked
- template transclusions^[i]
- citations or footnotes
- <math> markup
- images or icons

These restrictions are mandatory to avoid technical complications and are not subject to override by local consensus or incompatible guidelines.

Hidden comments referring to a section heading or a whole section are best placed in the line below the heading. They can also be placed within the same line as the heading, but in that case they must be *inside* the `==` `==` markup:^[j]

```

✓== Implications ==
<!--This comment is placed correctly.-->

✓== Implications<!--This comment works fine.--> ==

✓== <!--This comment works fine.-->Implications ==

✗== Implications == <!--This comment causes problems.-->

✗<!--This comment causes problems.
-->== Implications == [k]

✗<!--The space after this comment breaks the heading
completely.--> == Implications ==

```

Anchors

Before changing a heading, consider whether you might be breaking existing links to it. If there are many links to the old title,^[l] create an anchor with that title to ensure that these still work. Similarly, when linking to a section, leave an invisible comment at the heading of the target section, naming the linking articles, so that if the heading is later altered these can be easily fixed, or alternatively another anchor can be created if there are many.^[l] For example:

```

== {{subst:Anchor|Consequences}} Implications ==
<!-- "Richard Dawkins" and "Daniel Dennett" link here. -->

```

which will be saved in the article as:

```

== <span class="anchor" id="Consequences"></span> Implications ==
<!-- "Richard Dawkins" and "Daniel Dennett" link here. -->

```

The advantage of using `{{subst:Anchor}}`, or simply inserting the `<span>` tags directly, is that when edits are made to the section in the future, the anchor will not be included in page history entries as part of the section name. When just `{{Anchor}}` is used directly, that undesirable behavior *does* occur, so one should always substitute anchors in section headers. When inserting the span directly, *do not* abbreviate it by using a self-closing tag, as in:

==

In HTML5 that XML-style syntax is valid only for certain tags, such as `<br />`.^[1] See [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Linking § Avoiding broken section links](#) for further discussion.

Heading-like material

The guidance above for section headings, specifically sentence case, redundancy, images and questions, also applies to [table headings](#) (and of table columns and rows). However, table headings can incorporate citations and may begin with, or be, numbers. Unlike page headings, table headers do not automatically generate link anchors. Aside from sentence case in [glossaries](#), the heading advice also applies to the *term* entries in description lists. If using [template-structured glossaries](#), terms will automatically have link anchors, but will not otherwise. Citations for description-list content go in the `{{term}}` or `{{defn}}` element, as needed.

National varieties of English

See also: [Wikipedia:Article titles § National varieties of English](#), [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Spelling](#), and [Wikipedia:Article titles § English-language titles](#)

National varieties of English (for example, [American English](#) or [British English](#)) differ in vocabulary (*elevator* vs. *lift*), spelling (*center* vs. *centre*), and occasionally grammar (*see § Plurals, below*). Articles such as [English plurals](#) and [Comparison of American and British English](#) provide information about such differences. All national varieties of [Standard English](#) are equally acceptable on English Wikipedia, which uses a formal, encyclopedic [register](#) or tone.

An article's date formatting ([July 18, 2026](#) vs. [18 July 2026](#)) is also related to national varieties of English – see [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Strong national ties to a topic](#) and [Retaining existing format](#).

Consistency within articles

See also: [Wikipedia:Citing sources § Variation in citation methods](#), and [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Retaining existing format](#)

The conventions of a particular variety of Standard English should be followed consistently within a given article. Exceptions include:

- **Quotations and titles of works** (such as books, films, and music) should be given as they appear in sources. However, there are certain situations where this principle is not followed in order to maintain a level of typographic conformity across the encyclopedia. See [§ Typographic conformity](#).
- **Proper names** use the subject's own spelling, e.g., [joint project of the United States Department of Defense and the Australian Defence Force](#); [International Labour Organization](#).
- For articles about chemistry-related topics, the international standard spellings [aluminium](#), [sulfur](#), [caesium](#) (and derivative terms) should be used regardless of the variety of English otherwise employed in the article. See [Wikipedia:Naming conventions \(chemistry\) § Element names](#).

Opportunities for commonality

For an international encyclopedia, using vocabulary common to all varieties of English is preferable.

- Use universally accepted terms rather than those less widely distributed, especially in titles. For example, [glasses](#) is preferred to the national varieties [spectacles](#) (British English) and [eyeglasses](#) (American English); [ten million](#) is preferable to [one crore](#) (Indian English).
- If a variant spelling appears in a title, make a [redirect](#) page to accommodate the others, as with [artefact](#) and [artifact](#), so that all variants can be used in searches and linking.
- Terms that differ between varieties of English, or that have divergent meanings, may be glossed to prevent confusion, for example, [the trunk \(American English\) or boot \(British English\) of a car](#)
- Use a commonly understood word or phrase in preference to one that has a different meaning because of national differences (rather than [alternate](#), use [alternative](#) or [alternating](#), as appropriate), except in technical contexts where such substitution would be inappropriate ([alternate leaves](#); [alternate law](#)).
- When more than one variant spelling exists within a national standard variety of English, the most commonly used current variant (across all varieties of Standard English) should usually be preferred, except where the less common spelling has a specific usage in a specialized context, e.g., [connexion](#) in [Methodist connexionalism](#).

For assistance with specific terms, see [Comparison of American and British English § Vocabulary](#), and [American and British English spelling differences](#); most dictionaries also indicate regional terms.

Strong national ties to a topic

See also: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Strong national ties to a topic](#), and [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Unit choice and order](#)

An article on a topic that has strong ties to a particular [English-speaking nation](#) should use the standard (formal, not colloquial) English of that nation. For example:

- [Afrikaners](#) (South African English)
- [American Civil War](#) (American English)
- [Australian Defence Force](#) (Australian English)
- [Christchurch](#) (New Zealand English)
- [Dublin](#) (Hiberno-English)
- [Great Fire of London](#) (British English)
- [Lagos](#) (Nigerian English)
- [Muhammad Ali Jinnah](#) (Pakistani English)
- [Mumbai](#) (Indian English)
- [Vancouver](#) (Canadian English)
- [Wanchai Tower](#) (Hong Kong English)

For topics with strong ties to the [Commonwealth of Nations](#), or multiple Commonwealth countries or other [former British territories](#), use British spelling.

Retaining the existing variety

See also: [§ Retaining existing styles](#), [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Retaining the existing format](#), and [Wikipedia:Article titles § National varieties of English](#)

"WP:RETAIN" redirects here. For the general editing policy, see [Wikipedia:Editing policy § Try to fix problems](#).

When an English variety's consistent usage has been established in an article, maintain it in the absence of consensus to the contrary. Only very exceptionally (such as when a topic has strong national ties, or the change reduces ambiguity) is there a valid reason for changing from one acceptable option to another. When no English variety has been established and discussion does not resolve the issue, use the variety found in the first post-stub revision that introduced an identifiable variety. An exception to this is do not change the variety of English within a quotation.

The established variety in a given article is documented by placing the appropriate [Use X English template](#) on the article page. The appropriate [variety of English template](#) can also be placed on its talk page.

An article should not be edited or renamed simply to switch from one variety of English to another. `{{subst:uw-engvar}}` may be placed on an editor's talk page to explain this.

Capital letters

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters](#)

Wikipedia article titles and section headings use sentence case, not title case; see [Wikipedia:Article titles](#) and [§ Section headings](#). For capitalization of list items, see [§ Bulleted and numbered lists](#). Other points concerning capitalization are summarized below. Full information can be found at [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters](#). The central point is that Wikipedia does not capitalize something unless it is consistently capitalized in a substantial majority of independent, reliable sources.

Capitalization of *The*

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters § Capitalization of The](#)

Generally, do not capitalize the word *the* in mid-sentence: **throughout the United Kingdom**, not **throughout The United Kingdom**. Conventional exceptions include certain proper names (**he visited The Hague**) and most titles of creative works (**Tolkien wrote *The Lord of the Rings*** – but be aware that *the* might not be part of the title itself, e.g., **Homer composed the *Odyssey***).

There are special considerations for band names, institution names, nicknames, titles of works, and trademarks.

Titles of works

Main page: [WP:Manual of Style/Titles of works](#)

The English-language titles of compositions (books and other print works, songs and other audio works, films and other visual media works, paintings and other artworks, etc.) are given in *title case*, in which every word is given an initial capital except for certain less important words (as detailed at [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters § Composition titles](#)). The first and last words in an English-language title are always capitalized.

- *Correct: **An Eye for an Eye***

- **Correct:** *Worth the Fighting For*

Capitalization in non-English language titles varies, even over time within the same language; generally, retain the style of the original for modern works, and follow the usage in current^[m] English-language reliable sources for historical works. When written in the Latin alphabet, many of these items should also be in italics, or enclosed in quotation marks.

- **Correct:** *Les Liaisons dangereuses*
- **Correct:** "Hymnus an den heiligen Geist"

Titles of people

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Biography § Titles of people](#)

- **In generic use**, use lower case for words such as *president*, *king*, and *emperor* (*De Gaulle was a French president*; *Louis XVI was a French king*; *Three prime ministers attended the conference*).
- **Directly before the person's name**, such words begin with a capital letter (*President Obama*, not *president Obama*). Standard or commonly used names of an office are treated as proper names (*David Cameron was Prime Minister of the United Kingdom*; *Hirohito was Emperor of Japan*; *Louis XVI was King of France*). Royal styles take capitals (*Her Majesty*; *His Highness*); exceptions may apply for particular offices.

Religions, deities, philosophies, doctrines

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters § Religions, deities, philosophies, doctrines, and their adherents](#)

Further information: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Religion](#)

See also: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Titles § Religious texts](#)

- **Religions, sects, and churches** and their followers (in noun or adjective form) start with a capital letter. Generally, "the" is not capitalized before such names (*the Unitarians*, not *The Unitarians*).
- **Religious texts** are capitalized, but often not italicized (*the Bhagavad Gita*, *the Quran*, *the Talmud*, *the Granth Sahib*, *the Bible*). Do not capitalize "the" when using it in this way. Some derived adjectives are capitalized by convention, and some are not (*biblical*, but *Quranic*); if unsure, check a dictionary.
- **Honorifics for deities**, including proper names and titles, start with a capital letter (*God*, *Allah*, *the Lord*, *the Supreme Being*, *the Great Spirit*, *the Horned One*, *Bhagavan*). Do not capitalize "the" in such cases or when referring to major religious figures or characters from mythology (*the Prophet*, *the Messiah*, *the Virgin*). Common nouns for deities and religious figures are not capitalized (*many gods*; *the god Woden*; *saints and prophets*).
- **Pronouns for figures of veneration or worship** are not capitalized, even if capitalized in a religion's scriptures (*God and his will*).
- **Broad categories of mythical or legendary beings** start with lower-case letters (*elf*, *fairy*, *nymph*, *unicorn*, *angel*), although in works of fantasy, such as the novels of J. R. R. Tolkien and some video games, initial capitals are sometimes used to indicate that the beings form a culture or race in a fictional universe. Capitalize the names or titles of individual creatures (*the Minotaur*, *Pegasus*) and of groups whose name and

membership are fixed (**the Magi, or the Three Wise Men, the Furies**). Generalized references are not capitalized (**these priests; several wise men; cherub-like**).

- **Spiritual or religious events** are capitalized only when referring to specific incidents or periods (**the Great Flood and the Exodus**; but **annual flooding and an exodus of refugees**).
- **Philosophies, theories, movements, and doctrines** use lower case unless the name derives from a proper name (**capitalism versus Marxism**) or has become a proper name (**republican**, a system of political thought; **Republican**, a political party). Use lower case for doctrinal topics or canonical religious ideas (as opposed to specific events), even if they are capitalized by some religious adherents (**virgin birth, original sin, transubstantiation**).
- **Platonic or transcendent ideals** are capitalized in the context of philosophical doctrine (**Truth, the Good**); used more broadly, they are in lower case (**Superman represents American ideals of truth and justice**). Use capitals for personifications represented in art (**the guidebook mentioned statues of Justice and Liberty**).
- **Eponyms** are capitalized (**Edwardian, De Morgan's laws, Alice in Wonderland syndrome, plaster of Paris, Platonic idealism, Draconian constitution of Athens**), except in idiomatic uses disconnected from the original context and usually lower-cased in sources (**a platonic relationship; complained of draconian workplace policies**).^[n] An entire phrase in which an eponym is an adjective is not capitalized except when the phrase is itself a proper name (e.g., the title of a published work: *The China Syndrome*).

Calendar items

Main page: *Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters § Calendar items*

- **Months, days of the week, and holidays** start with a capital letter (**June, Monday; the Fourth of July** refers only to the US Independence Day – otherwise **July 4** or **4 July**).
- **Seasons** are in lower case (**her last summer; the winter solstice; spring fever**), except in personifications or in proper names for periods or events (**Old Man Winter; competed on the Spring Circuit**).

Animals, plants, and other organisms

For more detail on capitalization, see [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters § Animals, plants, and other organisms](#); on italicization, [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Text formatting § Italic type](#). See also [Wikipedia:Lead section § Organisms](#) for handling of first sentence. See [Wikipedia:Naming conventions \(fauna\)](#) and [Wikipedia:Naming conventions \(flora\)](#) for article title guidelines.

When using **taxonomic ("scientific") names**, capitalize and italicize the genus: *Berberis*, *Erithacus*. (Supergenous and subgenus, when applicable, are treated the same way.) Italicize but do not capitalize taxonomic ranks at the level of species and below: *Berberis darwinii*, *Erithacus rubecula superbus*, *Acacia coriacea* subsp. *sericophylla*; no exception is made for proper names forming part of scientific names. Higher taxa (order, family, etc.) are capitalized in Latin (**Carnivora, Felidae**) but not in their English equivalents (**carnivorans, felids**); they are not italicized in either form, except for viruses, where all names accepted by the [ICTV](#) are italicized (*Retroviridae*).

Cultivar and **cultivar group** names of plants are not italicized, and are capitalized (including the word *Group* in the name); cultivar names appear within single quotes (*Malus domestica* 'Red Delicious'), while cultivar groups do not (*Cynara cardunculus* Scolymus Group).

English vernacular ("common") names are given in lower case in article prose ([plains zebra](#), [mountain maple](#), and [southwestern red-tailed hawk](#)) and in sentence case at the start of sentences and in other places where the first letter of the first word is capitalized.^[f] They are additionally capitalized where they contain proper names: [Przewalski's horse](#), [California condor](#), and [fair-maid-of-France](#). This applies to species and subspecies, as in the previous examples, as well as to general names for groups or types of organism: [bird of prey](#), [oak](#), [great apes](#), [Bryde's whales](#), [livestock guardian dog](#), [poodle](#), [Van cat](#), [wolfdog](#). When the common name coincides with a scientific taxon, do not capitalize or italicize, except where addressing the organism taxonomically: [A lynx is any of the four medium-sized wild cat species within the genus *Lynx*](#). Non-English vernacular names, when relevant to include, are handled like any other non-English terms: italicized as such, and capitalized only if the rules of the native language require it. Non-English names that have become English-assimilated are treated as English ([ayahuasca](#), [okapi](#)).

Standardized breeds should generally retain the capitalization used in the breed standards.^[o] Examples: [German Shepherd](#), [Russian White goat](#), [Berlin Short-faced Tumbler](#). As with plant cultivars, this applies whether or not the included noun is a proper name, in contrast to how vernacular names of species are written. However, unlike cultivars, breeds are never put in single quotation marks, and their names are never part of a scientific name. A species term appended at the end for disambiguation ("cat", "hound", "horse", "swine", etc.) should not be capitalized, unless it is a part of the breed name itself and is consistently presented that way in the breed standards (rare cases include [Norwegian Forest Cat](#) and [American Quarter Horse](#)).

Create [redirects](#) from alternative capitalization and spelling forms of article titles, and from alternative names, e.g., [Adélie Penguin](#), [Adelie penguin](#), [Adelie Penguin](#) and [Pygoscelis adeliae](#) should all redirect to [Adélie penguin](#).

Celestial bodies

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters § Celestial bodies](#)

See also: [Wikipedia:Naming conventions \(astronomical objects\)](#)

The words *sun*, *earth*, *moon*, and *solar system* do not take capitals in general use ([The sun was over the mountain top](#); [The tribal people thought of the whole earth as their home](#)). They are capitalized when the entity is personified ([Sol Invictus \('Unconquered Sun'\) was the Roman sun god](#)) or when used as the name of a specific body in a scientific or astronomical context ([The Moon orbits the Earth](#); but [Io is a moon of Jupiter](#)).

Names of planets, moons, asteroids, comets, stars, constellations, and galaxies are proper names, and therefore capitalized ([The planet Mars is in the constellation Gemini, near the star Pollux](#)). The first letter of every word in such a name is capitalized ([Alpha Centauri](#) and not [Alpha centauri](#); [Milky Way](#), not [Milky way](#)). Words such as *comet* and *galaxy* should be capitalized when they form part of a proper name, but not when they are used as a generic term ([Halley's Comet is the most famous of the comets](#); [the Andromeda Galaxy is a spiral galaxy](#)).

Compass points

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters § Compass points](#)

Do not capitalize **directions** such as *north* or their related forms (*We took the northern road*) except when they are parts of proper names (*Great North Road, Great Western Drive, South Pole*).

Capitalize **names of regions** if they have attained proper-name status, including informal conventional names (*Southern California; the Western Desert*), and derived terms for people (e.g., a *Southerner* as someone from the *Southern United States*). Do not capitalize descriptive names for regions that have not attained the status of proper names, such as *southern Poland*.

Composite directions may or may not be hyphenated, depending on the variety of English adopted in the article. *Southeast Asia* and *northwest* are more common in American English; but *South-East Asia* and *north-west* in British English. In cases such as *north-south dialogue* and *east-west orientation*, use an en dash; see § *Other uses for en dashes*.

Proper names versus generic terms

Main pages: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters § Institutions](#), and [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters § Capitalization of The](#)

Capitalize names of particular institutions (*the founding of the University of Delhi; the history of Stanford University*) but not generic words for institutions (*the high school is near the university*). Do not capitalize *the* at the start of an institution's name, regardless of the institution's preferred style. There are rare exceptions, when a leading *The* is represented by a *T* in the organization's acronym: *The International Cat Association (TICA)*.

Treat political or geographic units similarly: *The city has a population of 55,000; The two towns merged to become the City of Smithville*. Do not mimic the style of local newspapers which refer to their municipality as *the City* or *The City*, except for the City of London *in some circumstances*.

This guidance extends to the output of institutions, companies, and other organizations. For example, the full name of legislation like *Online Safety Act 2023* would be capitalized, but subsequent references to *the act* would not.

Abbreviations

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Abbreviations](#)

See also: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Biography § Initials](#)

Abbreviations are shortened forms of words or phrases. In strict analysis, they are distinct from *contractions*, which use an *apostrophe* (e.g., *won't*, see § *Contractions*), and *initialisms*. An initialism is formed from some or all of the initial letters of words in a phrase. Below, references to abbreviations should be taken to include acronyms, and the term *acronym* should also apply to initialisms.

Write first occurrences in full

When an abbreviation will be used in an article, introduce it using the full expression, and the abbreviation in parentheses:

an early local area network (LAN) developed by Digital Equipment Corporation (DEC) ... DEC's later LAN products were ...

Do not use capitals in the full version merely because capitals are used in the abbreviation: **an early Local Area Network (LAN)**.

Except in special circumstances, common abbreviations (such as **PhD**, **DNA**, or **USSR**) need not be expanded even on first use.

Plural forms

Pluralize acronyms by adding -s or -es: **Three CD-ROMs and two BIOSes were released**. Do not use a *greengrocer's apostrophe* to form plurals: **Three CD-ROM's and two BIOS's were released**.

Punctuation and spacing

An abbreviation may or may not be terminated with a full point (also called a *period* or *full stop*). A consistent style should be maintained within an article. North American usage is typically to end all abbreviations with a period (**Dr. Smith of 42 Drummond St.**) but in common British and Australian usage, no period is used if the abbreviation (contraction) ends in the last letter of the unabbreviated form (**Dr Smith of 42 Drummond St**) unless confusion could result. This is also common practice in scientific writing. Regardless of punctuation, words that are abbreviated to more than one letter are spaced (**op. cit.** not **op.cit.** or **opcit**). There are some exceptions: **PhD** (*see above*) for "Philosophiae Doctor"; **BVetMed** for "Bachelor of Veterinary Medicine". In most situations, Wikipedia uses no such punctuation inside acronyms and initialisms: **GDP**, not **G.D.P.**

US and U.S.

"MOS:US" redirects here. For the use of the word "us", see Wikipedia:Manual of Style § First-person pronouns.

US is a commonly used abbreviation for **United States**, although **U.S.** – with periods and without a space – is common in North American publications, including in news journalism. Some American style guides, including *The Chicago Manual of Style* (since 2010), have deprecated **U.S.** and recommend **US**.

For commonality reasons, use **US** by default when abbreviating, but retain **U.S.** in American or Canadian English articles in which it is already established, unless there is a good reason to change it. Because use of periods for abbreviations and acronyms should be consistent within any given article, always use **US** in an article with other country abbreviations. In longer abbreviations that incorporate the country's initials (**USN**, **USAF**), never use periods. When the United States is mentioned with one or more other countries in the same sentence, **US** (or **U.S.**) may be too informal, especially at the first mention or as a noun instead of an adjective (**France and the United States**, not **France and the US**). Do not use the spaced **U. S.** or the archaic **U.S. of A.**, except when quoting.

Do not use **U.S.A.** or **USA** except in a quotation, as part of a proper name (**Team USA**), or in certain technical and formal uses (e.g., the ISO 3166-1 alpha-3, FIFA, and IOC country codes).

Circa

For examples, see [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Uncertain, incomplete, or approximate dates](#).

To indicate *approximately*, the use of {{circa}}, showing as , is preferred over circa, c., ca., or approx.

Avoid unwarranted use

See also: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Units of measurement for when to abbreviate units of measurement](#).

Avoid abbreviations when they might confuse the reader, interrupt the flow, or appear informal. For example:

- Do not use approx. for approximate(ly) except in an infobox or table (in which case use {{abbr|approx.|approximately}} at first occurrence:).
- Do not use the legalism Holmes J for Justice Holmes.

Do not invent

Avoid devising new abbreviations, especially acronyms. For example, World Union of Billiards is good as a *translation* of Union Mondiale de Billard, but neither it nor the reduction WUB is used by the organization or by independent sources; use the original name and its official abbreviation, UMB.

If it is necessary to abbreviate in a tight space, such as a column header in a table, use widely recognized abbreviations. For example, for New Zealand gross national product, use NZ and GNP, with a link if the term has not already been written out in the article: . Do not make up initialisms such as NZGNP.

HTML tags and templates

Either <abbr> or {{abbr}} can be used for abbreviations and acronyms: <abbr title="World Health Organization">WHO</abbr> or {{abbr|WHO|World Health Organization}} will generate WHO; hovering over the rendered text causes a tooltip of the long form to pop up.

Ampersand

"WP:&" redirects here. For the use of "and" in titles, see [Wikipedia:Article titles § Titles containing "and"](#).

In normal text and headings, use *and* instead of the ampersand (&): January 1 and 2, not January 1 & 2. But retain an ampersand when it is a legitimate part of the style of a proper noun, the title of a work, or a trademark, such as in *Up & Down* or AT&T. Elsewhere, ampersands may be used with consistency and discretion where space is extremely limited (e.g., tables and infoboxes). Quotations may be cautiously modified, especially for consistency where different editions are quoted, as modern editions of old texts routinely replace ampersands with *and* (just as they replace other disused glyphs, ligatures,

and abbreviations). Another frequent permissible but not required use is in short bibliographic references to works by multiple authors, e.g.: <ref>Lubbers & Scheepers (2002); Van Hiel & Mervielde (2002); Swyngedouw & Giles (2007); Van Hiel (2012).</ref>.

Italics

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Text formatting § Italic type](#)

Emphasis

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Text formatting § Emphasis](#)

Italics are used for emphasis, rather than [boldface](#) or [capitals](#). But overuse diminishes its effect: consider rewriting instead.

Use . . . or {{em| . . . }} for emphasis. This allows [user style sheets](#) to handle emphasis in a customized way, and helps reusers and translators.^[2]

- Correct: The meerkat is not actually a cat.
- Correct: The meerkat is {{em|not}} actually a cat.

Titles

For complete guidance on the handling of titles of works, see (until the material is better consolidated):

- [WP:Manual of Style/Titles of works](#) (overview and details)
- [WP:Manual of Style § Titles of works](#) (which summarizes the key points)
- [WP:Manual of Style/Text formatting § Names and titles](#) (provides greater detail than the section you are reading now)
- [WP:Manual of Style § Punctuation §§ Quotation marks §§§ Names and titles](#) (summarizes details at [WP:Manual of Style/Titles of works](#))
- [WP:Manual of Style/Lists of works](#)
- [WP:Manual of Style/Music § Capitalization](#)

Use italics for the titles of works (such as books, films, television series, named exhibitions, computer games, music albums, and artworks). The titles of articles, chapters, songs, episodes, storylines, research papers and other short works instead take double quotation marks.

Italics are not used for major religious works ([the Bible](#), [the Quran](#), [the Talmud](#)). Many of these titles should also be in [title case](#).

Words as words

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Text formatting § Words as words](#)

For the policy when a word or phrase itself may be an encyclopedic subject, see [Wikipedia:Wikipedia is not a dictionary § When a word or phrase may be an encyclopedic subject](#).

Use italics when *mentioning* a word or character (see [Use–mention distinction](#)) or a string of words up to one sentence ([the term *panning* is derived from *panorama*; the most common letter in English is *e*](#)). When a whole sentence is mentioned, double quotation marks may be used instead, with

consistency (*The preposition in **She sat on the chair is on**; or The preposition in "She sat on the chair" is "on"*). Quotation marks may also be used for shorter material to avoid confusion, such as when italics are already heavily used in the page for another purpose (e.g., for many non-English words and phrases). *Mentioning* (to discuss grammar, wording, punctuation, etc.) is different from *quoting* (in which something is usually expressed on behalf of a quoted source). Quotation is done with quotation marks, never italics, nor both at once (*see § Quotations for details*).

A closely related use of italics is when introducing or distinguishing terms: *The natural numbers are the integers greater than 0*.

Non-English words

Main page: *Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Text formatting § Non-English terms*

Italics are indicated for non-English phrases and isolated non-English words that are not commonly used in everyday English. However, proper names (such as place names) in other languages are not usually italicized, nor are terms in non-Latin scripts. The {{lang}} template and its variants support all [ISO 639](#) language codes, correctly identifying the language and automatically italicizing for you. Please use these templates rather than just manually italicizing non-English material. (*See WP:Manual of Style/Accessibility § Other languages for more information.*)

Scientific names

Use italics for the scientific names of plants, animals, and [all other organisms](#) except viruses at the [genus](#) level and below (italicize *Panthera leo* and *Retroviridae*, but not *Felidae*). The hybrid sign is not italicized (*Rosa × damascena*), nor is the "connecting term" required in [three-part botanical names](#) (*Rosa gallica* *subsp. officinalis*).

Quotations in italics

See also: § Quotations

Do not put quotations in italics. [Quotation marks](#) (or [block quoting](#)) alone are sufficient and the correct ways to denote quotations. Italics should only be used if the quoted material would otherwise call for italics. (*See below.*)

Italics within quotations

Use italics within quotations to reproduce emphasis that exists in the source material or to indicate the use of non-English words. The emphasis is better done with {{em}}. If it is not clear that the source already included italics (or some other styling) for emphasis, or to indicate when emphasis was not used in the original text but was editorially added later, add the editorial note [emphasis in original] or [emphasis added], respectively, after the quotation.

- For example: "Now cracks a noble heart. Good night sweet prince: And *flights of angels* sing thee to thy rest." [emphasis in original].

Effect on nearby punctuation

Italicize only the elements of the sentence affected by the emphasis. Do not italicize surrounding punctuation.

- *Incorrect:* **What are we to make of *that*?** (The question mark applies to the whole sentence, not just to the emphasized *that*, so it should not be italicized.)
- *Correct:* **What are we to make of *that*?**
- *Correct:* **Four of Patrick White's most famous novels are *A Fringe of Leaves*, *The Aunt's Story*, *Voss*, and *The Tree of Man*.** (The commas, the period, and the word *and* are not italicized.)

Quotations

Further information: [Wikipedia:Do not include the full text of lengthy primary sources](#)
"[MOS:QUOTE](#)" redirects here. For the section on quotation characters, see [Wikipedia:Manual of Style § Quotation characters](#). For the essay, see [Wikipedia:Quotations](#).

Brief quotations of copyrighted text may be used to illustrate a point, establish context, or attribute a point of view or idea. While quotations are an indispensable part of Wikipedia, excessive use of them is incompatible with an encyclopedic writing style and may be [copyright infringement](#), so most of the content should be in the editor's own words. Consider paraphrasing quotations into plain and concise text when appropriate (while being aware that [close paraphrasing](#) can still violate copyright). [Do not put quotations in italics](#) unless the material would be italicized for some other reason.

Per the [verifiability policy](#), direct quotations *must* be accompanied by an [inline citation](#) from a [reliable source](#) that supports the material. This is especially important in articles that are about or contain material about [living or recently deceased people](#) (BLPs).

Original wording

"WP:PMC" redirects here. For closure of requested moves by page movers, see [Wikipedia:Requested moves/Closing instructions § Closure by a page mover](#).

"WP:PLC" redirects here. For inclusion guidelines for organizations, see [Wikipedia:Notability \(organizations and companies\)](#). For the handling of the abbreviation "plc" in article titles, see [Wikipedia:Naming conventions \(companies\)](#).

Quotations must be [verifiably](#) attributed, and the wording of the quoted text must be faithfully reproduced. This is referred to as the *principle of minimal change*. Where there is good reason to change the wording, square bracket the changed text; for example, "**Ocyrhoe told him his fate**" might be quoted as "**Ocyrhoe told [her father] his fate**". Insignificant spelling and typographic errors should simply be silently corrected (for example, correct **basicy** to **basically**). If there is a significant error in the original, follow it with {{sic}} (producing [sic]) to show that the error was not made by Wikipedia; for example, "**his interview with the Dolly Llama [sic]**". When applied to text that is linked, the syntax of the template may be adjusted to {{sic|nolink=y}} (producing [sic] in the resulting linked text; for example in the link: [sic] template).^[p] For the sake of accuracy and indexing, the titles of referenced sources should not be corrected for spelling, but minor typographic adjustments (like changing [curly quotes](#) to straight) may be made silently. Inline citations in the quoted text, to sources not used in the Wikipedia article, should be silently removed.

Use ellipses to indicate omissions from quoted text. Legitimate omissions include extraneous, irrelevant, or parenthetical words, and unintelligible speech (**umm** and **hmm**), but do not omit text where doing so would remove important context or alter the meaning of the text. Vulgarities and obscenities should be shown exactly as they appear in the quoted source; Wikipedians should never bowdlerize words (**G-d d--n it!**), but if the text being quoted *itself* does so, copy the text verbatim and use {{sic}} to indicate that the text is quoted as shown in the source.

In direct quotations, retain dialectal and archaic spellings, including capitalization (but not archaic glyphs and ligatures, as detailed below in § Typographic conformity).

Point of view

See also: Wikipedia:Neutral point of view § Attributing and specifying biased statements, and Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Words to watch § Expressions of doubt

Quotation should be used, with attribution, to present emotive opinions that cannot be expressed in Wikipedia's own voice, but never to present cultural norms as simply opinionial:

- Acceptable: **Siskel and Ebert called the film "unforgettable".**
- Unacceptable: **The site is considered "sacred" by the religion's scriptures.**

Concise opinions that are not overly emotive can often be reported with attribution instead of direct quotation. Use of quotation marks around simple descriptive terms can imply something doubtful regarding the material being quoted; sarcasm or weasel words such as *supposedly* or *so-called*, might be inferred.

- Permissible: **Siskel and Ebert called the film interesting.**
- Unnecessary and may imply doubt: **Siskel and Ebert called the film "interesting".**
- Should be quoted: **Siskel and Ebert called the film "interesting but heart-wrenching".**

Typographic conformity

"MOS:CONFORM" redirects here. For consistency within articles, see Wikipedia:Manual of Style § Consistency within articles.

A quotation is not a facsimile and, in most cases, it is not a requirement that the original formatting be preserved. Formatting and other purely typographical elements of quoted text^[q] should be adapted to English Wikipedia's conventions without comment, provided that doing so will not change or obscure meaning or intent of the text. These are alterations which make no difference when the text is read aloud, for example:

- Normalize dashes and hyphens: see § Dashes. Use the style chosen for the article: unspaced em dash or spaced en dash.
- Convert apostrophes and quotation marks to Wikipedia's style:
 - These should be straight, not curly or slanted. See § Quotation marks.
 - When quoting a quotation that itself contains a quotation, alternate between using double and single quotes for each quotation. See § For a quotation within a quotation for details.
- When quoting text from non-English languages, the outer punctuation should follow the Manual of Style for English quote marks. If there are nested quotations, follow the rules for

correct punctuation in that language. If there are multiple styles for a language, the one used by the Wikipedia for that language is preferred unless the punctuation itself is under discussion.

The cynical response "L'auteur aurait dû demander : « à quoi sert-il d'écrire ceci ? » mais ne l'a pas fait" was all he wrote.

- Remove spaces before punctuation such as periods and colons.
- Generally preserve bold and italics (see § *Italics*), but most other styling should be altered. **Underlining**, **spacing** within words, **colors**, **ALL CAPS**, **SMALL CAPS**, etc. should generally be normalized to plain text. If it *clearly* indicates emphasis, use italic *emphasis* (`{{em}}`) or, in an already-italic passage, boldface (with `{{strong}}`). For titles of books, articles, poems, and so forth, use italics or quotation marks following the guidance for titles. Italics can also be added to mark up non-English terms (with the `{{lang}}` template), for an organism's scientific name, and to indicate a words-as-words usage.
- Expand an abbreviation (not already used in the content before the quotation) as a square-bracketed change, or explain it using `{{abbr}}`.
- Normalize archaic glyphs and ligatures in English that are unnecessary to the meaning (except in proper names and for languages where ligatures are standard, per § *Ampersand* and § *Ligatures*). Examples include *æ* → *ae*, *œ* → *oe*, *ſ* → *s*, and *p^e* → *the*.

See *Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Titles § Typographic conformity* for special considerations in normalizing the typography of titles of works.

However, national varieties should not be changed, as these may involve changes in vocabulary. For example, a quotation from a British source should retain British spelling, even in an article that otherwise uses American spelling. (See § *Consistency within articles*.)

Numbers also usually should not be reformatted.

Direct quotation should not be used to preserve the formatting preferred by an external publisher (especially when the material would otherwise be unchanged), as this tends to have the effect of scare-quoting:

- *Acceptable*: The animal is listed as endangered on the IUCN Red List of Threatened Species.
- *Unacceptable*: The animal is listed as "Endangered" on the IUCN Red List of Threatened Species.

Italics can be used to mark a particular usage as a term of art (a case of "words as words"), especially when it is unfamiliar or should not be reworded by a non-expert:

- *Permissible*: The animal is listed as *critically endangered* on the IUCN Red List of Threatened Species.

When quoting a complete sentence, it is usually recommended to keep the first word capitalized. However, if the quoted passage has been integrated into the surrounding sentence (for example, with an introduction such as "X said that"), the original capital letter may be lower-cased.

- LaVesque's report stated: "The equipment was selected for its low price. This is the primary reason for criticism of the program."
- LaVesque's report said that "the equipment was selected for its low price".
- The program was criticized primarily because "the equipment was selected for its low price", according to LaVesque.

It is normally unnecessary to note changes in capitalization. However, for more precision, the altered letter may be put inside square brackets: "The" → "[t]he".

- The program was criticized primarily because "[t]he equipment was selected for its low price", according to LaVesque.

Attribution

The reader must be able to determine the source of any quotation, at the very least via a footnote. The source must be named *in article text* if the quotation is an opinion (see *Wikipedia:Neutral point of view § Attributing and specifying biased statements*). When attributing a quotation, avoid characterizing it in a biased manner.

Quotations within quotations

See § For a quotation within a quotation.

Linking

Be conservative when linking within quotations; link only to targets that correspond to the meaning clearly intended by the quote's author. Where possible, link from text outside of the quotation instead – either before it or soon after. (If quoting hypertext, add an editorial note, [link in original] or [link added], as appropriate, to avoid ambiguity as to whether the link was made by the original author.)

Block quotations

Format a long quotation (more than about forty words or a few hundred characters, or consisting of more than one paragraph, regardless of length) as a block quotation, using the `{{blockquote}}` template. The text presented in block quotations and quote boxes (see below) should not itself be enclosed in quotation marks (including large, "decorative"-type quotation marks). Block quotations and quote boxes using a colored background are also discouraged.

Use `{{blockquote}}` and similar markup only for actual quotations; indentation for other purposes is done differently.

It is conventional to precede a block quotation with an introductory sentence (or sentence fragment) and append the source citation to that line. Alternatively, the `{{blockquote}}` template provides parameters for attribution and citation which will appear below the quotation. (*For use of dashes with attributions, see § Other uses for em dashes.*) This below-quotation attribution style is intended for famous quotations and is unusual in articles because it may strike an inappropriate tone. A quotation with no cited source should be flagged with `{{quote without source}}`, or deleted.

Since line breaks and indentation are generally ignored inside `{{blockquote}}` or `<blockquote>`, use `<poem>` or `{{poem quote}}` for poetry, lyrics, and similar material. Such material can also be quoted inline, with line breaks indicated by `{{nbsp}}`/`/`, and paragraph or stanza breaks by `{{nbsp}}`/`//`. For example: "And, as in uffish thought he stood, / The Jabberwock, with

eyes of flame, / Came whiffing through the tulgey wood, / And burbled as it came! // One, two! One, two! And through and through / The vorpal blade went snicker-snack!"

A `{{Quote box}}` is an alternative to an inline quote or a block quote. Quote boxes are displayed in a stand-alone manner (similar to images) and are best suited to noteworthy or important quotations. They can create point of view or undue weight issues, because the quotations are not put in context or integrated into the text of the article. Therefore, they must be used with particular care.

Pull quotes do not belong in Wikipedia articles. These are the news and magazine style of "pulling" material already in the article to reuse it in attention-grabbing decorative quotations. This unencyclopedic approach is a form of editorializing, produces out-of-context and undue emphasis, and may lead the reader to conclusions not supported in the material.

Excessive quotation of copyrighted text (whether or not formatted as a blockquote, and even if credited to its source) is prohibited. See Wikipedia:Quotations § Copyrighted material and fair use.

Non-English quotations

Quotations from non-English language sources should appear with a translation into English, preferably a modern^[m] one. Quotations that are translations should be explicitly distinguished from those that are not. Indicate the original source of a translation (if it is available, and not first published within Wikipedia), and the original language (if that is not clear from the context).

If the original, untranslated text is available, provide a reference for it or include it, as appropriate.

When editors themselves translate text into English,^[r] care must always be taken to include the original text, *in italics* (except for non-Latin-based writing systems, and best done with the `{{lang}}` or `{{langx}}` templates, which both italicize as appropriate and provide language metadata); and to use actual and (if at all possible) common English words in the translation. Unless you are certain of your competency to translate something, see Wikipedia:Translation for assistance.

Punctuation

For a brief guide to how some punctuation marks are used in Wikipedia for special purposes, e.g., description lists, see Help:Punctuation.

Apostrophes

- Use straight apostrophes (`'`), not curly apostrophes (`'`). Do not use accent marks or backticks (```) as apostrophes.
- Templates such as `{{`}}` and `{{`s}}` are helpful when an apostrophe (or single quote) appears at the beginning or end of text in italics or bold, because italics and bold are themselves indicated by sequences of single quotes.
 - When an apostrophe follows italicized text, `{{'}}` or `{{'s}}` can be used to additionally prevent the last letter of the right-leaning text from intersecting the

apostrophe. Example: the *Iliad*'s themes (markup: the ''Iliad''{{'s}} themes).

- Letters resembling apostrophes and curly quotes, such as the ʻokina (ʻ – inserted using {{okina}}), salttillo (ʼ – {{salttillo}}), Hebrew אֵי or Arabic اَ (ʼ – {{ayin}}), and Arabic hamza (ْ – {{hamza}}), should be represented by those templates or by their respective Unicode characters. (Basic Arabic transliteration, which uses an ASCII apostrophe, is preferred in most cases by [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Arabic](#); these other characters are only used in strict transliteration.)
 - Templates cannot be used in article titles; use the corresponding Unicode character directly. Per [Wikipedia:Article titles § Special characters](#), also make a redirect from the ASCII form to aid searches. Forms without apostrophe-like characters are sometimes preferred by [Wikipedia:Article titles § Use commonly recognizable names](#) (e.g. [Hawaii](#) but not [Kealiʻi Reichel](#)).

See also [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Hawaii-related articles § Orthography, spelling and formatting](#)

- For [Wade–Giles](#) romanizations of Mandarin Chinese, use {{wg-apos}}.
- For languages with ejective consonants and the like, use {{hamza}}.
- For the Cyrillic [soft sign](#), when indicated at all, use {{softsign}} or {{hamza}}.
- For usage of the possessive apostrophe, see [§ Possessives](#).
- For further treatment of apostrophe usage (possessive, elision, formation of certain plurals, non-English language issues), see the article [Apostrophe](#).

Quotation marks

See also: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style § Quotations](#)

In the material below, the term *quotation* includes conventional uses of quotation marks such as for titles of songs, chapters, episodes, and so on. Quotation marks are also used in other contexts, such as in [cultivar names](#).

Quotation characters

- Use "straight" quotation marks, not “curly” ones. (For [single quotes](#): 'straight', not ‘curly’.)
- Do not use accent marks, backticks (`text´), low–high („“), corner brackets (⌈ ⌋), or guillemets (« ») as quotation marks (except when such marks are *internal* to quoted non-English text – see [§ Typographic conformity](#)). The symbols ´ and ” seen in edit window dropdowns are ["prime"](#) and ["double prime"](#) respectively: these are used to designate [units of angular measurement](#), and not as apostrophes or quote marks.
- Quotation marks and apostrophes in imported material [should be changed](#) if necessary to comply with the above.

Double or single

- Most quotations take double quotation marks (Welles said: "It was a terrible situation."),^[s] except nested quotations (see below).
- Plant cultivars take single quotation marks (*Malus domestica* 'Golden Delicious'; see [Wikipedia:Naming conventions \(flora\)](#)).

- Glosses that translate or define unfamiliar terms (when using the words as words) take single quotes; simple glosses require no comma before the definition (*Cossack originates from Cuman *qazaq 'freebooter'; republic comes from Latin res publica, loosely meaning 'public affair'.*). The {{Gloss}} template can be used for this; e.g. {{lang|es|casa}} {{gloss|house}} yields: casa 'house'.

For a quotation within a quotation

Use single quotes:

- Darwin wrote in his introduction that "the maxim 'de minimis lex non curat' does not apply to science".

For deeper nesting, alternate between single and double quotes:

- He said, "That book asserts, 'Confucius said "Everything has beauty, but not everyone sees it."'"

For quote marks in immediate succession, add a sliver of space by using {{' '}}, {{' '}}, or (as in the example just given) {{' ' ' '}}:

- He announced, "The answer was 'Yes!'" Markup: He announced, "The answer was 'Yes!{{' ' ' '}}"
- He announced, "The answer was 'Yes!'" (simply jamming things together looks bad in most fonts)
- He announced, "The answer was 'Yes!' " (a regular space is too much)

Article openings

In the bolded text typically appearing at the opening of an article:

- Any quotation marks that are part of the title should be in bold just like the rest of the title.
 - From *"A" Is for Alibi*: **"A" Is for Alibi** is a mystery novel ...
- Quotation marks *not* part of the article title should not be bolded.
 - From *Jabberwocky*: **"Jabberwocky"** is a nonsense poem ...
 - From *Babe Ruth*: **George Herman "Babe" Ruth** was an American baseball player ... (See also *Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Biography § Nicknames.*)

Punctuation before quotations

If a non-quoted but otherwise identical construction would work grammatically without a comma, using a comma before a quotation embedded within a sentence is optional:

- The report stated "There was a 45% reduction in transmission rate." (Cf. the non-quotation The report stated there was a 45% reduction in transmission rate.)
- The report stated, "There was a 45% reduction in transmission rate."

The comma-free approach is often used with partial quotations:

- The report observed "a 45% reduction in transmission rate".

A comma is required when it would be present in the same construction if none of the material were a quotation:

- In Margaret Mead's view, "we must recognize the whole gamut of human potentialities" to enrich our culture.

Do not insert a comma if it would confuse or alter the meaning:

- Caitlyn Jenner expressed concerns about children "who are coming to terms with being true to who they are". (Accurate quote of a statement about *some* children – specifically those children "who are coming to terms ...")
- Caitlyn Jenner expressed concerns about children, "who are coming to terms with being true to who they are". (Changes the meaning to imply Jenner was expressing concern about *all* children, while separately observing that children, in general, "are coming to terms ...")

It is clearer to use a colon to introduce a quotation if it forms a complete sentence, and this should always be done for multi-sentence quotations:

- The report stated: "There was a 45% reduction in transmission rate."
- In a letter to his son, Albert Einstein wrote: "Life is like riding a bicycle. To keep your balance you must keep moving."

No additional punctuation is necessary for an explicit words-as-words scenario:

- The message was unintelligible except for the fragments "help soon" and "how much longer before".

Names and titles

For complete guidance on the handling of titles of works, see (until the material is better consolidated):

- WP:Manual of Style/Titles of works (overview and details)
- WP:Manual of Style § Titles of works (which summarizes the key points)
- WP:Manual of Style § Italics §§ Titles, and WP:Manual of Style/Text formatting § Names and titles (both summarize details at WP:Manual of Style/Titles of works)
- *the section you are reading now*
- WP:Manual of Style/Lists of works
- WP:Manual of Style/Music § Capitalization

Quotation marks should be used for the following names and titles:

- Articles and chapters (books and periodicals italicized)
- Short stories (books and periodicals italicized)
- Sections of musical pieces (pieces italicized)
- Individual strips from comics and webcomics (comics italicized)
- Poems (long or epic poems italicized)
- Songs (albums, song cycles, operas, operettas, and oratorios italicized)
- Individual episodes of television and radio series and serials (series title italicized)^[t]

*Correct: The Beatles wrote "Lucy in the Sky with Diamonds" for their album *Sgt. Pepper's Lonely Hearts Club Band*.*

Do not use quotation marks or italics for ancient writings, concert tours, locations, prayers, myths, and epics. (Many, but not all, of these items should also be in title case.)

Punctuation inside or outside

See also: *Wikipedia:Logical quotation on Wikipedia* and *Wikipedia:Manual of Style § Effect on nearby punctuation*

Use the logical quotation style in all articles, regardless of the variety of English in which they are written. Include terminal punctuation within the quotation marks only if it was present in the original material, and otherwise place it after the closing quotation mark. For the most part, this means treating periods and commas in the same way as question marks: keep them inside the quotation marks if they apply only to the quoted material and outside if they apply to the whole sentence. Examples are given below.

- **Correct:** Did Darla say, "Here I am"? (question mark applies to whole sentence)
- **Incorrect:** Did Darla say, "Here I am?" (incorrect to apply the question mark to the quotation)
- **Correct:** Darla said, "Where am I?" (question mark applies to quoted material only)

If the quotation is a single word or a sentence fragment, place the terminal punctuation outside the closing quotation mark. When quoting a full sentence, the end of which coincides with the end of the sentence containing it, place terminal punctuation inside the closing quotation mark.

- Miller wanted, he said, "to create something timeless".
- Miller said: "I wanted to create something timeless."

If the quoted sentence is followed by a clause that should be preceded by a comma, omit the full stop (period), and do not replace it with a comma *inside* the quotation.^[u] Other terminal punctuation, such as question marks or exclamation marks, may be retained.

- Livingston then said, "It is done", and turned to the people.
- Livingston then exclaimed, "It is done!", and turned to the people.

If the quoted sentence is followed by a clause identifying the speaker, use a comma outside the quotation mark instead of a full stop inside it, but retain any other terminal punctuation, such as a question mark.

- "There is no strife, no prejudice, no national conflict in outer space as yet", said Kennedy.
- By asking "Who are you?", she prompts John to tell his story.

Do not follow quoted words or fragments with commas inside the quotation marks, except where a longer quotation has been broken up and the comma is part of the full quotation.

- **Correct:** "I began to change, opening the way to confidence and courage", said Turner.
- **Correct:** "I began to change," said Turner, "opening the way to confidence and courage."
- **Correct:** "I began to change, opening the way", said Turner, "to confidence and courage."
- **Incorrect:** "I began to change, opening the way," said Turner, "to confidence and courage."

Quotation marks and external links

External links to article titles should have the title in quotes inside the link. The CS1 and CS2 citation templates do this automatically, and untemplated references should do the same.

- *Correct:* [Kiefer, Francine \(May 29, 1998\). "Clinton: The Early Years" \(https://www.csmonitor.com/1998/0529/052998.us.us.3.html\). *The Christian Science Monitor*](https://www.csmonitor.com/1998/0529/052998.us.us.3.html). (Using `{{cite news}}`)
- *Correct:* [Kiefer, Francine \(May 29, 1998\). "Clinton: The Early Years" \(https://www.csmonitor.com/1998/0529/052998.us.us.3.html\). *The Christian Science Monitor*](https://www.csmonitor.com/1998/0529/052998.us.us.3.html). (Untemplated)
- *Incorrect:* [Kiefer, Francine \(May 29, 1998\). "Clinton: The Early Years \(https://www.csmonitor.com/1998/0529/052998.us.us.3.html\)". *The Christian Science Monitor*](https://www.csmonitor.com/1998/0529/052998.us.us.3.html). (Untemplated)

Quotation marks and internal links

Internal links (wikilinks) accompanied by quotation marks should usually have the quotes outside the link. This applies to titles of works in quotation marks (songs, episodes, etc.)

- *Correct:* [Play it, Sam. Play "As Time Goes By"](#). (Using `"[[ ]]"`.)
- *Incorrect:* [Play it, Sam. Play "As Time Goes By"](#). (Using `[" "]`.)

However, quotation marks are needed inside wikilinks when the quotation mark is part of the link, or where the linked display text includes quotation marks indicating slang, nicknames, common names, or similar usage.

- *Correct:* [The term *soccer* comes from Oxford "-er" slang, which was prevalent at the University of Oxford in England from about 1875...](#)
- *Correct:* [A Cockney accent drops the "r" after a vowel.](#)
- *Correct:* [The Proletarian Sports Society "Dynamo" was established in Moscow in 1923.](#)
- *Correct:* [President Suharto's "New Order" administration received US support for its economic policies.](#)
- *Correct:* [Japan's "Lost Decades" began in 1991.](#)

Brackets and parentheses

"MOS:PAREN" redirects here. For use of parentheses (round brackets) in article titles, see WP:Article titles § Parenthetical disambiguation. For deprecated inline parenthetical citations, see WP:Citing sources § Parenthetical referencing.

This section applies to both round brackets (), often called parentheses, and square brackets [].

If a sentence contains a bracketed phrase, place the sentence punctuation outside the brackets ([as shown here](#)). However, where one or more sentences are wholly inside brackets, place their punctuation inside the brackets. There should be no space next to the inner side of a bracket. An opening bracket should usually be preceded by a space. This may not be the case if it is preceded by an opening quotation mark, another opening bracket, or a portion of a word:

- [He rose to address the meeting: "\(Ahem\) ... Ladies and gentlemen, welcome!"](#)

- Only the royal characters in the play ([Prince] Hamlet and his family) habitually speak in blank verse.
- We journeyed on the Inter[continental].
- Most people are right-handed. (Some people are left-handed, but that does not make right-handed people "better" than left-handed people.)

There should be a space after a closing bracket, except where a punctuation mark follows (though a spaced dash would still be spaced after a closing bracket) and in unusual cases similar to those listed for opening brackets.

Avoid adjacent sets of brackets. Either put the parenthetical phrases in one set separated by semicolons, or rewrite:

- *Avoid:* Nikifor Grigoriev (c. 1885 – 1919) (also known as Matvii Hryhoriiv) was a Ukrainian insurgent leader.
- *Better:* Nikifor Grigoriev (c. 1885 – 1919; also known as Matvii Hryhoriiv) was a Ukrainian insurgent leader.
- *Better:* Nikifor Grigoriev (c. 1885 – 1919) was a Ukrainian insurgent leader. He was also known as Matvii Hryhoriiv.

Square brackets are used to indicate editorial replacements and insertions within quotations, though this should never alter the intended meaning. They serve three main purposes:

- To clarify: She attended [secondary] school, where this was the intended meaning, but the type of school was unstated in the original sentence.
- To reduce the size of a quotation: X contains Y, and under certain circumstances, X may contain Z as well may be reduced to X contains Y [and sometimes Z]. When an ellipsis (...) is used to indicate that material is removed from a direct quotation, it should not normally be bracketed. (See *§ Ellipses for an exceptional case.*)
- To make the grammar work: Referring to someone's statement "I hate to do laundry", one could properly write She "hate[s] to do laundry".

If a sentence includes subsidiary material enclosed in square or round brackets, it must still carry terminal punctuation *after* those brackets, regardless of any punctuation within the brackets.

She refused all requests (except for basics such as food, medicine, etc.).

However, if the entire sentence is within brackets, the closing punctuation falls within the brackets. (This sentence is an example.)

Brackets and linking

Square brackets inside of links must be escaped:

He said, "[[John Doe John [Doe]]] answered."	He said, "John [Doe] answered."
He said, "[[John Doe John {{bracket Doe}}]] answered."	He said, "John [Doe] answered."
[https://example.com On the first day [etc.]]	<u>On the first day [etc.] (https://example.com)</u>
[https://example.com On the first day {{bracket etc.}}]	<u>On the first day [etc.] (https://example.com)</u>

The `<nowiki>` markup can also be used: `<nowiki>[Doe]</nowiki>` or `<nowiki>[etc.]</nowiki>`.

If a URL itself contains square brackets, the wikitext should use the URL-encoded form `https://example.com/foo.php?query=%5Bxxx%5Dyyy`, rather than `...query=[xxx]yyy`. This will avoid truncation of the link after xxx.

Angle brackets

For guillemets (« »), see § Quotation characters

Angle brackets ($\langle \rangle$) are used in various technical subjects, such as in physics for bra–ket notation and expectation value (e.g. $\langle \varphi | \psi \rangle$), in mathematics for the presentation of a group, and in linguistics to denote graphemes (e.g. **the digraph** $\langle sh \rangle$). Do not use less-than and greater-than signs ($< >$) as angle brackets (e.g. $< \varphi | \psi >$, **the digraph** $< sh >$).

Ellipses

Use an *ellipsis* if material is omitted in the course of a quotation, unless square brackets are used to gloss the quotation.

- For prose and non-LaTeX mathematics formulae, ellipses are written using three unspaced dots (`. . .`); do not use the precomposed ellipsis character (`...`) or three dots separated by spaces (`. . .`)
- Generally, use a non-breaking space before an ellipsis and a regular space after it:
Alpha, Bravo,{{nbsp}}... Zulu
- If an ellipsis is followed by `. ? ! : ; , ) ] }` or a closing quotation mark (single or double), omit the space after it. Place terminal punctuation inside the quote only if it is textually important, as is often the case with exclamation marks and question marks but rarely with periods:

Jones wrote: "These stories amaze me. The facts suffer so frightfully{{nbsp}}..."
"But what of the other cities? London, Paris{{nbsp}}...?"
- If the ellipsis immediately follows an opening quotation mark, only use a non-breaking space after it:

He continued to pursue Smith ("...{{nbsp}}to the ends of the earth", he had sworn) until his own death.

- To distinguish an ellipsis that indicates omitted text from one that is part of the quote, you can surround the former with square brackets: *She retorted: "How do I feel? How do you think I ... This is too much! [...] Take me home!"*
- When an ellipsis is used to represent a pause in or suspense of speech, retain the original punctuation: *Virginia's startled reply was "Could he ...? No, I can't believe it!"*. When used inside an incomplete word, no space is used between the word fragment(s) and the ellipsis: *The garbled transmission ended with "We are stranded near San L...o", interpreted as either San Leandro or San Lorenzo.*
- In LaTeX-formatted mathematics formulae, use the proper LaTeX markup for lowered dots (`\dots`, `\ldots`) or the precomposed characters that have dots in other positions (such as centered or diagonal, `\cdots`, `\cdot`, or `\cdot`.)

Commas

A pair of commas can bracket an appositive, relative clause, or parenthetical phrase (as can brackets or dashes, though with greater interruption of the sentence). For example:

Correct: John Smith, Janet Cooper's son, is a well-known playwright.

Correct: Janet Cooper's son John Smith is a well-known playwright. (when Janet has multiple sons)

Correct: Janet Cooper's son, John Smith, is a well-known playwright. (when Janet has only one son)

Always use a *pair* of commas for this, unless another punctuation mark takes the place of the second comma:

Correct: Blunt comments came from the newest member, John Smith.

Correct: The newest member, John Smith – a retired teacher – was blunt.

Incorrect: The newest member, John Smith was blunt.

Don't let other punctuation distract you from the need for a comma, especially when the comma collides with a bracket or parenthesis:

Correct: Burke and Wills, fed by locals (on beans, fish, and *ngardu*), survived for a few months.

Incorrect: Burke and Wills, fed by locals (on beans, fish, and *ngardu*) survived for a few months.

In geographical references that include multiple levels of subordinate divisions (e.g. city, state/province, country), a comma separates each element and follows the last element unless followed by terminal punctuation or a closing parenthesis. The last element is treated as parenthetical.

Correct: He traveled through North Carolina before staying in Chattanooga, Tennessee, for the night.

Incorrect: He traveled through North Carolina before staying in Chattanooga, Tennessee for the night.

Also include commas when the geographical element is used as a disambiguator:

Correct: Hantratty received a PhD from the University of California, Irvine, in 1977.

Incorrect: Hantratty received a PhD from the University of California, Irvine in 1977.

Include a second comma also when a construction with a comma modifies a noun or compound noun:

Correct: Keith Wilson won the 2024 Portland, Oregon, mayoral election.

Incorrect: Keith Wilson won the 2024 Portland, Oregon mayoral election.

Dates in month–day–year format require a comma after the day, as well as after the year, unless followed by other punctuation. The last element is treated as parenthetical.

Correct: He set October 1, 2011, as the deadline for Patterson to meet his demands.

Incorrect: He set October 1, 2011 as the deadline for Patterson to meet his demands.

Place quotation marks by following § Punctuation inside or outside. This is known as "logical quotation".

Correct: She said, "The weather changes too often", and made other complaints.

Incorrect: She said, "The weather changes too often," and made other complaints.

A comma may be included before a quotation embedded within a sentence (see § Quotation marks).

Serial commas

"MOS:OXFORD" redirects here. For Oxford spelling, see Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Spelling § British English with "-ize" (Oxford spelling).

A serial comma (sometimes also known as an *Oxford comma* or *Harvard comma*) is a comma used immediately before a conjunction (*and*, *or*, *nor*) in a list of three or more items.

ham, chips, and eggs – serial comma

ham, chips and eggs – no serial comma

Editors may use either convention so long as each article is internally consistent. Serial commas are more helpful when article text is complex, such as a list with multi-word items (especially if one contains its own "and") or a series of probably unfamiliar terms.

However, there are cases in which either omitting or including the serial comma results in ambiguity:

The author thanked her friends, Sinéad O'Connor and Bob Marley – which may list either four or more people (the friends and the two people named) or two people (O'Connor and Marley, who are the friends).

The author thanked a friend, Sinéad O'Connor, and Bob Marley – which may list either two people (O'Connor, who is the friend, and Marley) or three people (the first being the friend, the second O'Connor, and the third Marley).

In such cases of ambiguity, clarify one of four ways:

- Add or remove the serial comma.
- Use separate sentences, bullet lists, or some other structural change to clarify.

- Recast the sentence ("friends" case):
 - To list two people: The author thanked her friends Sinéad O'Connor and Bob Marley.
 - Clearer: The author thanked two friends: Sinéad O'Connor and Bob Marley.
 - To list several people:
 - The author thanked Sinéad O'Connor, Bob Marley and her friends or
 - The author thanked Sinéad O'Connor, Bob Marley, and her friends.
 - But not: The author thanked Bob Marley, Sinéad O'Connor[,] and her friends – introduces ambiguity about *her*.
- Recast the sentence ("friend" case):
 - To list two people: The author thanked Bob Marley and her friend Sinéad O'Connor.
 - Or be more specific when possible: The author thanked her childhood friend Sinéad O'Connor and her mentor, Bob Marley.
 - To list three people: The author thanked Bob Marley, Sinéad O'Connor, and a friend.
 - Clarity with gender-specific terms such as *mother* can be tricky; The author thanked her mother, Kim Thayil, and Sinéad O'Connor is unclear because readers may not know Kim Thayil is male and wouldn't be the same person as the mother.
 - Clearer: The author thanked Kim Thayil, Sinéad O'Connor, and her own mother or The author thanked her mother and musicians Kim Thayil and Sinéad O'Connor.

Colons

For the wikitext link formatting, see [Help:Colon trick](#).

A colon (:) introduces something that demonstrates, explains, or modifies what has come before, or is a list of items that has just been introduced. The items in such a list may be separated by commas, or if they are more complex and perhaps themselves contain commas, the items should be separated by semicolons or arranged in a bulleted list.

We visited several tourist attractions: the Leaning Tower of Pisa, which I thought could fall at any moment; the Bridge of Sighs; the supposed birthplace of Petrarch, or at least the first known house in which he lived; and so many more.

A colon may also be used to introduce direct speech enclosed within quotation marks. (See [§ Quotation marks](#).)

When a colon is being used as a separator in an article title, section heading, or list item, editors may choose whether to capitalize what follows, taking into consideration the existing practice and consistency with related articles.

Except in technical usage (a **3:1 ratio**), no sentence should contain multiple colons, no space should precede a colon, and a space (but never a hyphen or dash) should follow the colon.

Semicolons

For usage in marking up description (definition) lists, see [Help:List § Description lists](#).

A semicolon (;) is sometimes an alternative to a full stop (period), enabling related material to be kept in the same sentence; it marks a more decisive division in a sentence than a comma. If the semicolon separates clauses, normally each clause must be independent (meaning that it could stand on its own as a sentence). In many cases, only a comma or only a semicolon will be correct in a given sentence.

Correct: **Though he had been here before, I did not recognize him.**

Incorrect: **Though he had been here before; I did not recognize him.**

Above, "Though he had been here before" cannot stand on its own as a sentence, and therefore is not an independent clause.

Correct: **Oranges are an acidic fruit; bananas are classified as alkaline.**

Incorrect: **Oranges are an acidic fruit, bananas are classified as alkaline.**

This incorrect use of a comma between two independent clauses is known as a comma splice; however, in certain kinds of cases, a comma may be used where a semicolon would seem to be called for:

Accepted: **"Life is short, art is long."** (two brief clauses in an aphorism; see *Ars longa, vita brevis*)

Accepted: **"I have studied it, you have not."** (reporting brisk conversation, such as this reply of Newton's)

A sentence may contain several semicolons, especially when the clauses are parallel in construction and meaning; multiple unrelated semicolons are often signs that the sentence should be divided into shorter sentences or otherwise refashioned.

Unwieldy: **Oranges are an acidic fruit; bananas are classified as alkaline; pears are close to neutral; these distinctions are rarely discussed.**

Better: **Oranges are an acidic fruit, bananas are alkaline, and pears are close to neutral; these distinctions are rarely discussed.**

Semicolons are used in addition to commas to separate items in a listing, when commas alone would result in confusion.

Confusing: **Sales offices are located in Boston, Massachusetts, San Francisco, California, Singapore, and Millbank, London, England.**

Clear: **Sales offices are located in Boston, Massachusetts; San Francisco, California; Singapore; and Millbank, London, England.**

Semicolon before "however"

The meaning of a sentence containing a trailing clause that starts with the word *however* depends on the punctuation preceding that word. A common error is to use the wrong punctuation, thereby changing the meaning to one not intended.

When the word *however* is an adverb meaning "nevertheless", it should be preceded by a semicolon and followed by a comma. Example:

It was obvious they could not convert these people; however, they tried.

Meaning: It was obvious they could not convert these people; nevertheless, they tried.

When the word *however* is a conjunction meaning "in whatever manner", or "regardless of how", it may be preceded by a comma but not by a semicolon, and should not be followed by punctuation. Example:

It was obvious they could not convert these people, however they tried.

Meaning: It was obvious they could not convert these people, regardless of how they tried.

In the first case, the clause that starts with "however" cannot be swapped with the first clause; in the second case this can be done without change of meaning:

However they tried, it was obvious they could not convert these people.

Meaning: Regardless of how they tried, it was obvious they could not convert these people.

If the two clauses cannot be swapped, a semicolon is required.

A sentence or clause can also contain the word *however* in the middle, if it is an adverb meaning "although" that could have been placed at the beginning but does not start a new clause in mid-sentence. In this use, the word may be enclosed between commas. Example:

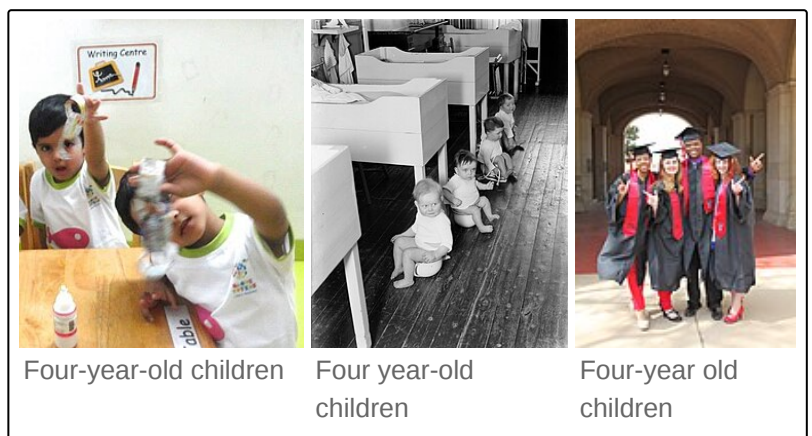
He did not know, however, that the venue had been changed at the last minute.

Meaning: However, he did not know that the venue had been changed at the last minute.

Hyphens

Hyphens (-) indicate conjunction. There are three main uses:

1. In hyphenated personal names (John Lennard-Jones, Omar al-Bashir).
2. To link prefixes and suffixes with their main terms in certain constructions, unless the compounds themselves include a space or hyphen: quasi-scientific, ultra-nationalistic, London-based, community-led.



- A hyphen may be used to distinguish between homographs (re-dress means *dress again*, but redress means *remedy* or *set right*).

- There is a clear trend to join both elements in all varieties of English (**subsection**, **nonlinear**). Hyphenation clarifies when the letters brought into contact are the same (**non-negotiable**, **sub-basement**) or are vowels (**pre-industrial**), or where a word is uncommon (**co-proposed**, **re-target**) or may be misread (**sub-era**, not **subera**). Some words of these sorts are nevertheless common without the hyphen (e.g., **cooperation** is more frequently attested than **co-operation** in contemporary English). Beware of words that change their meaning without the hyphen, e.g. **re-creation** (create again) and **recreation** (amusement).^[m]



A man eating fish



A man-eating fish



Officials help dog-bite victim.



Officials help dog bite victim.

3. To link related terms in compound modifiers:^[v]

- Hyphens can aid ease of reading (that is, they can be **ease-of-reading** aids) and are particularly useful in long noun phrases: **gas-phase reaction dynamics**. But never insert a hyphen into a proper name (**Middle Eastern cuisine**, not **Middle-Eastern cuisine**).
- A hyphen can help to disambiguate (some **short-story writers** are quite tall; **a government-monitoring program** is a program that monitors the government, whereas **a government monitoring program** is a government program that monitors).
- Compounds that are hyphenated when used *attributively* (adjectives before the nouns they qualify: **a light-blue handbag**, **a 34-year-old woman**) or *substantively* (as a noun: **she is a 34-year-old**) are usually not hyphenated when used *predicatively* (descriptive phrase separated from the noun: **the handbag was light blue**, **the woman is 34 years old**). Where there would otherwise be a loss of clarity, however, a hyphen may be used in the predicative form as well (**hand-fed turkeys**, **the turkeys were hand-fed**). Awkward attributive hyphenation can sometimes be avoided with a simple rewording: **Hawaiian-native species** → **native Hawaiian species**.
- Avoid using a hyphen after a standard -ly adverb (**a newly available home**, **a wholly owned subsidiary**) unless part of a larger compound (**a slowly-but-surely strategy**). In rare cases, a hyphen can improve clarity if a rewritten alternative is awkward, but rewording is usually preferable: **The idea was clearly stated enough** can be disambiguated as **The idea clearly was stated often enough** or **The idea was stated with enough clarity**.



A sign exhibiting over-eager hyphenation (not to mention capitalization): the second hyphen belongs, but the first does not.

- A few words ending in *-ly* function as both adjectives and adverbs (a **kindly-looking teacher**; a **kindly provided facility**). Some such dual-purpose words (like **early**, **only**, **northerly**) are not standard *-ly* adverbs, because they are not formed by addition of *-ly* to an independent current-English adjective. These need careful treatment: **Early flowering plants appeared around 130 million years ago**, but **Early-flowering plants risk damage from winter frosts**; **only child actors** (no adult actors) but **only-child actors** (actors without siblings).
- A hyphen is normally used when the adverb *well* precedes a participle used attributively (a **well-meaning gesture**; but normally a **very well managed firm**, because *well* itself is modified) and even predicatively, if *well* is necessary to, or alters, the sense of the adjective rather than simply intensifying it (**the gesture was well-meaning**, **the child was well-behaved**, but **the floor was well polished**).
- In some cases, such as **diode-transistor logic**, the independent status of the linked elements requires an en dash instead of a hyphen.
- Use a **suspended hyphen** (also called a *hanging hyphen*) when two compound modifiers are separated (**two- and three-digit numbers**; a **ten-car or -truck convoy**; **sloping right- or leftward**).
- Values and units used as compound modifiers are hyphenated only where the unit is given as a whole word; when using the unit symbol, separate it from the number with a non-breaking space (;).
 - *Incorrect*: **9-mm gap**
Correct: **9 mm gap** (markup: 9 mm gap)
 - *Incorrect*: **9 millimetre gap**
Correct: **9-millimetre gap**
 - *Correct*: **12-hour shift**
Correct: **12 h shift** (markup: 12 h shift)

Multi-word hyphenated items: It is often possible to avoid multi-word hyphenated modifiers by rewording (a **four-CD soundtrack album** may be easier to read as a **soundtrack album of four CDs**). This is particularly important where converted units are involved (**the 6-hectare-limit (14.8-acre-limit) rule** might be possible as **the rule imposing a limit of six hectares (14.8 acres)**, and the ungainly **4.9-mile (7.9 km) -long tributary** as simply **4.9-mile (7.9 km) tributary**).

For optional hyphenation of compound **points of the compass** such as *southwest/south-west*, see § Compass points.

Do not use a capital letter after a hyphen except for a proper name following the hyphen: **Graeco-Roman** and **Mediterranean-style**, but not **Gandhi-Like**. In titles of published works, when given in title case, follow the capitalization rule for each part independently (*The Out-of-Towners*), unless reliable sources consistently do otherwise in a particular case (*The History of Middle-earth*).

Hyphenation rules in other languages may be different. Thus, in French a place name such as **Trois-Rivières** ('Three Rivers') is hyphenated, when it would not be in English. Follow reliable sources in such cases.

Spacing: A hyphen is never followed or preceded by a space, except when hanging (*see above*) or when used to reference parts of words independently, such as **the prefix sub-** and **the suffix -less**.

Image filenames and redirects: Image filenames are not part of the encyclopedic content; they are tools. They are most useful if they can be readily typed, so they usually use hyphens instead of dashes. Similarly, article titles with dashes should also have a corresponding redirect from a copy of the title with hyphens: for example, [Michelson-Morley experiment](#) redirects to [Michelson–Morley experiment](#).

Non-breaking: A non-breaking hyphen (`{\nbhyph}`) will *not* be used as a point of line-wrap.

Soft hyphens: Use to mark locations where a word will be broken and hyphenated *if necessary* at the end of a line of text, usually in or narrow spaces (such as captions, narrow table columns, or text adjacent to a very wide image), for example: `Pennsylvania and Massachusetts style themselves commonwealths.`. Use sparingly to avoid making wikitext difficult to read and edit. For more information, see [Help:Line-break handling](#).

Encoding: The hyphen is represented by the ASCII/UNICODE HYPHEN-MINUS character, which is entered by the hyphen or minus key on all standard keyboards. Do not use the UNICODE HYPHEN character.

Dashes

"WP:DASH" redirects here. For the overview of Wikipedia discussions, see Wikipedia:Dashboard.

Two forms of dash are used on Wikipedia: **en dash** (–) and **em dash** (—). To enter them, click on them in the CharInsert toolbar, type `{{endash}}` or `{{emdash}}`, or use other methods.

Do not use one or more hyphens in place of a dash.

To ensure the consistent and clear use of dashes, Wikipedia adopts the following principles:

To mark divisions within a sentence

Dashes are often used to mark divisions within a sentence: in pairs (parenthetical dashes, instead of parentheses or pairs of commas) or singly (perhaps instead of a colon). They may also indicate an abrupt stop or interruption in reporting quoted speech. In all such cases, either unspaced em dashes or spaced en dashes can be used, with consistency maintained throughout a given article:

- An em dash is *unspaced* on both sides:
Another "planet" was detected—but it was later found to be a moon of Saturn.
- An en dash is *spaced* on both sides:
Another "planet" was detected – but it was later found to be a moon of Saturn.

Ideally, an en dash should be preceded by a non-breaking space; this prevents the dash from appearing at the beginning of a line. The `{{sند}}` template may be used for this:

Another "planet" was detected{{snd}}but it was later found to be a moon of Saturn.

Do not insert any spaces where an en dash should be unspaced (see § *Other uses for en dashes*).

Dashes can clarify a sentence's structure when commas, parentheses, or both are also being used.

- The book summarizes works of some major philosophers in chronological order: Descartes, Locke, Hume – but not his *Treatise* (deemed too complex for the target audience) – and Kant.

Use dashes sparingly. More than two in a single sentence makes the structure unclear; it takes time for the reader to see which dashes form a pair, if any.

- The birds – at least the ones Darwin collected – had red and blue feathers.
- "We have run aground at – ", was the final, incomplete message received from the ship.
- Avoid: First – at a marshy site leveled with landfill – came the workshop – then administrative and other buildings.
- Better: First – at a marshy site leveled with landfill – came the workshop; administrative and other buildings were erected later.

In ranges that might otherwise be expressed with *to* or *through*

This section is about ranges of numbers, dates, or times. For other ranges, such as ranges of physical locations, see § In compounds when the connection might otherwise be expressed with to, versus, and, or between.

See also: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Ranges](#)

For ranges between numbers, dates, or times, use an en dash:

- pp. 7–19; 64–75%; Henry VIII reigned 1509–1547^[w]

Do not change hyphens to dashes in filenames, URLs, or templates such as `{{Bibleverse}}` (which formats verse ranges into URLs), even if a range is embedded in them.

Do not mix en dashes with *between* or *from*.

- 450–500 people
- between 450 and 500 people, not between 450–500 people
- from 450 to 500 people, not from 450–500 people
- from 1961 to 1964, not from 1961–1964
- between the 1961–1962 and 1967–1968 seasons or between the 1961–62 and 1967–68 seasons

The en dash in a range is always unspaced, except when either or both elements of the range include at least one space, hyphen, or en dash; in such cases, `{{snd}}` between them will provide the proper formatting.

- July 23, 1790 – December 1, 1791 (not July 23, 1790–December 1, 1791)
- 14 May – 2 August 2011 (not 14 May–2 August 2011)
- 1–17 September (and note in this case that the second element of the range is 17, not 17 September); February–October 2009; 1492 – 7 April 1556
- Christmas Day – New Year's Eve; Christmas 2001 – Easter 2002; 10:30 pm Tuesday – 1:25 am Wednesday; 6:00 p.m. – 9:30 p.m. (but 6:00–9:30 p.m.)

- wavelengths in the range 28 mm – 17 m.
- pages 5-7 – 5-9

If negative values are involved, an unspaced en dash might be confusing:

- –10 to 10, not –10-10 (though –10 – 10 might work in a table consistently formatted with x–y constructions)

In compounds when the connection might otherwise be expressed with *to*, *versus*, *and*, or *between*

Use an unspaced en dash when the relationship between components of a compound is parallel, symmetric, equal, oppositional, or at least involving *separate or independent elements*. The components may be nouns, adjectives, verbs, or any other independent part of speech. Often, if the components are reversed there would be little change of meaning.

- boyfriend-girlfriend problems; a New York-Los Angeles flight
- rapid walk-dance transitions; male-female height ratio; red-green colorblind; red and green are separate independent colors, not mixed
- a 51-30 win; a 22-17 majority vote;^[3] but prefer spelling out when using words instead of numerals: a six-to-two majority decision, not with the awkward six-two; avoid confusingly reversed order: a 17-22 majority vote^[x]
- a 50-50 joint venture; a 60-40 split; avoid using a slash (stroke) here, which indicates division
- the east-west runway; a carbon-carbon bond; the Uganda-Tanzania War; the Lincoln-Douglas debates
- on-off switch; push-pull output; the analog-digital distinction
- a pro-establishment-anti-intellectual alliance; Singapore-Sumatra-Java shipping lanes
- Wrong: an iron-roof shed; *iron* modifies *roof*, so use a hyphen: an iron-roof shed
- Wrong: a singer-songwriter; not separate persons, so use a hyphen: a singer-songwriter
- Wrong: blue-green algae; a blended, intermediate color, so use a hyphen: blue-green algae

Generally, use a hyphen in compounded proper names of single entities.

- Guinea-Bissau; Bissau is its capital, and this name distinguishes the country from neighboring Guinea
- Wilkes-Barre, a single city named after two people, but Minneapolis-Saint Paul, an area encompassing two cities
- John Lennard-Jones, an individual named after two families

Use an en dash between the names of nations or nationalities when referring to an association between them. For people and things identifying with multiple nationalities, use a hyphen when using the combination adjectivally and a space when they are used as nouns, with the first used attributively to modify the second.

- an Italian-Swiss border crossing; but an Italian-Swiss newspaper for Italian-speaking Swiss

- France–Britain rivalry; French–British rivalry
- an Indian-American scientist; was especially popular with Indian Americans
- Wrong: **Franco–British rivalry**; *Franco-* is a *combining form*, not an independent word, so use a hyphen: **Franco-British rivalry**

A slash or some other alternative may occasionally be better to express a ratio, especially in technical contexts (see § *Slashes*). However, use a colon for strictly numeric ratios, to avoid confusion with subtraction or division:

- the protein–fat ratio; the protein/fat ratio; the protein-to-fat ratio
- a 3:1 ratio; a three-to-one ratio (see *Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Fractions and ratios*).

Use an en dash for the names of two or more entities in an attributive compound.

- the Seifert–van Kampen theorem; the Alpher–Bethe–Gamow theory
- the Seeliger–Donker-Voet scheme (developed by Seeliger and Donker-Voet)
- Comet Hale–Bopp or just Hale–Bopp (discovered by Hale and Bopp)

Do not use an en dash for hyphenated personal names, even when they are used as adjectives:

- **Lennard–Jones potential** with a hyphen: named after John Lennard-Jones

When applying a prefix or suffix to a compound that itself includes a space, hyphen, or dash

Use an en dash when adding a prefix or suffix to a compound that itself includes:

- a space:
 - ex-prime minister Thatcher (consider recasting: former prime minister Thatcher)
 - pre-World War II aircraft
 - New York-based company
 - late 19th century-style architecture
 - post-September 11 anti-war movement
- a hyphen:
 - Musk with then-president-elect Trump
 - long-term-focused investment plan
 - high-resolution-capable display
 - state-of-the-art-level performance
- or a dash:
 - corrections in Thomas–Fermi-based models
 - advanced post-Hartree–Fock calculations

The form of category names follows the corresponding main articles, e.g., Category:Trans-New Guinea languages. However, the principle is sometimes not extended to other category names, such as "related lists" categories,^[4] e.g., Category:Tennis-related lists and Category:Table tennis-

related lists both use hyphens.

To separate parts of an item in a list

Spaced en dashes are sometimes used between parts of list items. For example:

- James Galway – flute; Anne-Sophie Mutter – violin; Maurizio Pollini – piano.

or

- "The Future" – 7:21
- "Ain't No Cure for Love" – 6:17
- "Bird on the Wire" – 6:14

Editors may choose whether to capitalize what follows, taking into consideration the existing practice and consistency with related articles.

Other uses for en dashes

The en dash (–) has several common functions beyond its use in lists and running text. It is used to *join* components less strongly than a hyphen would (*see § Hyphens*); conversely, it may also *separate* components less strongly than a slash would (*see § Slashes*). Consider the relationship that exists between two components when deciding what punctuation to place between them.

Other uses for em dashes

An indented em dash may be used when attributing the source of a passage, such as a block quotation or poem. This dash should not be fully spaced: however, for reasons related to metadata and accessibility, it is best to place a hair space between the dash and the name.^[y] Most of Wikipedia's quotation templates provide this formatting automatically.

For example, {{in5}}–{{hair space}}Charlotte Brontë produces:

—Charlotte Brontë

In article titles

In article titles, do not use a hyphen (-) as a substitute for an en dash, for example in *eye–hand span* (since *eye* does not modify *hand*). Nonetheless, to aid searching and linking, provide a redirect with hyphens replacing the en dash(es), as in *eye-hand span*. Similarly, provide category redirects for categories containing dashes. When a dash is being used as a separator in an article title or section heading, editors may choose whether to capitalize what follows, taking into consideration the existing practice and consistency with related articles.

Other dashes

Do not use typewriter approximations or other substitutes, such as two hyphens (--), for em or en dashes.

For a negative sign or subtraction operator use U+2212 – MINUS SIGN (−), which can also be generated by clicking on the – following the ± in the **Insert** toolbar beneath the edit window. Do not use U+2212 – MINUS SIGN inside a `<math>` tag, as the character gives a syntax error; instead use a normal

Slashes

"WP:SLASH" redirects here. For information on subpages, which contain a slash in their titles, see [Wikipedia:Subpages](#).

Generally, avoid joining two words with a slash (a.k.a. forward slash, stroke, or solidus), because it suggests that the words are related without specifying how. Replace with clearer wording. In circumstances involving a distinction or disjunction, the en dash (*see above*) is usually preferable to the slash: **the digital-analog distinction**.

For example: **The parent/instructor must be present at all times**.

- Must both be present? → **The parent and the instructor**
- Must at least one be present? → **The parent or the instructor**
- Are they the same person? → **The parent-instructor**

An unspaced slash may be used:

- to indicate phonemic pronunciations (***rivet** is pronounced /'rɪvət/*);
- in a fraction (**7/8** or $x^n/n!$), but prefer the division operator ($\div$) when representing elementary arithmetic in prose (**10 $\div$ 2 = 5**) and a fraction bar ($\frac{x^n}{n!}$) in more advanced mathematical formulas (*see [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers §§ Common mathematical symbols](#) and [Fractions and ratios](#) and [Help:Displaying a formula](#)*);
- to indicate regular defined yearly periods that do not coincide with calendar years (e.g., **the 2009/2010 fiscal year**), if that is the convention used in reliable sources (*see [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Long periods of time](#) for further explanation*);
- to express a ratio, in a form in which a slash is conventionally used (e.g., **the price-to-earnings ratio**, or **P/E ratio for short**);

A spaced or unspaced slash may be used:

- in an expression or abbreviation widely used outside Wikipedia (e.g., **N/A** for *[not applicable](#)* or **the NY 31 east / NY 370 exit**).

A spaced slash may be used:

- to separate run-on lines in quoted poetry or song (**To be or not to be: that is the question: / Whether 'tis nobler in the mind to suffer / The slings and arrows of outrageous fortune**);
- rarely, to mark paragraph breaks in quoted prose, where they are textually important.

To avoid awkward line breaks, code spaced slashes (and fraction slashes) with a non-breaking space on the left and a normal space on the right, as in: My mama told me / You better shop around. For short constructions, both spaces should be non-breaking: N / A. On the other hand, if two long words are connected by an unspaced slash, a `{{wbr}}` added after the slash will allow a line break at that point.

Do not use the backslash character (`\`) in place of a slash.

And/or

Avoid writing **and/or** unless other constructions would be lengthy or awkward. Instead of **Most had trauma and/or smoke inhalation**, write simply **trauma or smoke inhalation** (which would normally be interpreted as an inclusive *or* to imply *or both*); or, for emphasis or precision or both, write **trauma or smoke inhalation or both**. Where more than two possibilities are present, instead of **x, y, and/or z** write **one or more of x, y, and z** or **some or all of x, y, and z**.

Symbols

Unicode symbols are preferred over composed ASCII symbols for improved readability and accessibility. Be mindful of presentations that may require ASCII, like source code. Keys for these symbols can be found at the bottom of the Source Editor.

Composed ASCII symbol	Preferred symbol
-->	→
<--	←
<--> or <->	↔
^	↑
>=	≥
<=	≤
~=	≈

Number (pound, hash) sign and numero

*For pound sterling and other currency symbols, see Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Currencies and monetary values.
See also: Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers*

Avoid using the **#** symbol (known as the number sign, hash sign, pound sign, or octothorpe) when referring to numbers or rankings. Instead write **number**, **No.** or **Nos.**; do not use the symbol **№**. For example:

- Incorrect:

Her album reached **#1** in the UK albums chart.
- Correct:

Her album reached **number one** in the UK albums chart.
Her albums *Foo* and *Bar* reached numbers one and three in the UK albums chart.
- Correct:

Her album reached **No. 1** in the UK albums chart.
Her albums *Foo* and *Bar* reached **Nos. 1 and 3**.

Exceptions:

- Issue numbers of comic books which, unlike other periodicals, are conventionally presented in text with the form **#1**, unless a volume is also given, in which case write **volume two**, **number seven** or **Vol. 2**, **No. 7**.
- Periodical publications carrying both issue *and* number designations (typically one being a year-relative and the other an absolute value); they should be given in the form **2 #143** in citations, or be spelt out as **Iss. 2**, **No. 143** in text.

When using the abbreviations, write **{{abbr|Vol.|Volume}}**, **{{abbr|Iss.|Issue}}**, **{{abbr|No.|Number}}**, or **{{abbr|Nos.|Numbers}}**, at first occurrence.

Terminal punctuation

"MOS:PERIOD" redirects here. For the use of three periods in succession, see § Ellipses. For periods of time, see Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Ranges.

Question marks or exclamation marks have almost no application in encyclopedic writing. Where a word or phrase that includes terminal punctuation ends a sentence, do not add a second terminal punctuation mark. If the word or phrase ends in a question mark or exclamation mark, readers may find the sentence

confusing, so it is usually better to reword so that the mark appears mid-sentence.

- Incorrect:* **Slovak returned to the Red Hot Chili Peppers in 1985 after growing tired of What Is This?.**
- Acceptable:* **Slovak returned to the Red Hot Chili Peppers in 1985 after growing tired of What Is This?**
- Better:* **Slovak, having grown tired of What Is This?, returned to the Red Hot Chili Peppers in 1985.**
- Incorrect:* **He made several films with Sammy Davis Jr..**
- Correct:* **He made several films with Sammy Davis Jr.**

Not all contexts require terminal punctuation. Captions, list entries, and similar sentence fragments in most cases should not end with a period. Such constructions may also begin with a lowercase letter in some situations; see § Formatting of captions and § Bulleted and numbered lists. For guidance specific to captions and lists, see § Formatting of captions and § Bulleted and numbered lists.

Punctuation and footnotes

See also: Wikipedia:Citing sources

Footnotes (also called *endnotes* or simply *notes*), used as citation footnotes and sometimes explanatory notes, are created using **reference tags** (`<ref> . . . </ref>`). Reference tags should *immediately* follow the text to which the footnote applies, with no intervening space.^[z] Apart from the exceptions listed below, references are placed *after* adjacent punctuation, not before. Adjacent reference tags should have no space between them, nor should there be any between tags and inline dispute and cleanup templates. For example:

- **Flightless birds have a reduced keel,^[10] and they also have smaller wing bones than flying birds of similar size.^{[11][12]}**

However, reference tags are placed *before* dashes, not after. If a footnote applies only to material within parentheses, the tags belong just before the closing parenthesis. For example:

- **Paris is not the capital city of England—the capital of which is London^[10]—but that of France.^[11]**
- **Kim Jong-un (Korean: 김정은; Hanja: 金正恩^[10]) is the Supreme Leader of North Korea.^[11]**

When reference tags are used, a footnote list must be added, and this is usually placed in the References section, near the end of the article in the standard appendices and footers.

Punctuation after formulae

Place punctuation after mathematical formulae in sentences as if they were normal body text. See Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Mathematics § Punctuation after formulae.

Spacing

Words and sentences are separated by a single space. In the wiki source, repeated spaces or a single newline may also be used, since these are rendered as a single space.

Never put a space before a comma, semicolon, colon, period, question mark, or exclamation mark, even in quoted material.

Dates and time

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Chronological items](#)

Dates should not be linked unless there is a significant connection to the subject, as discussed at [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Linking § Chronological items](#). For ranges of dates and times, see [§ Other uses for en dashes](#).

Time of day

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Times of day](#)

Times of day are normally expressed in figures rather than words. Context determines whether the 12- or the 24-hour format is more appropriate.

- Twelve-hour clock times are written in one of two forms: **11:15 a.m.** and **2:30 p.m.**, or **11:15 am** and **2:30 pm** (wherein the spaces should be non-breaking). Use **noon** and **midnight** rather than **12 pm** and **12 am**; it may need to be specified whether *midnight* refers to the start or end of a date.
- Twenty-four-hour clock times are written in the form **08:15** and **22:55**, with no suffix. Midnight written as **00:00** begins the day; **24:00** ends it.

Dates

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Dates, months, and years](#)

Full dates are formatted **10 June 1921** or **June 10, 1921**; or where the year is omitted, use **10 June** or **June 10**.

- The dates in the *text* of any one article should all have the same format (day-first or month-first).
 - For date formats in citations, see [Wikipedia:Citing sources § Citation style](#).
 - Dates in quotations and titles are always left as-is.
 - If a numerical format is required (e.g., for conciseness in lists and tables), use the YYYY-MM-DD format: **2005-04-23**.
- Articles on topics with strong ties to a particular English-speaking country should generally use the more common date format for that country (month-first for the US, except in military usage; day-first for most others; articles related to Canada may use either consistently). Otherwise, do not change an article from one date format to the other without good reason.

Months

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Dates, months, and years](#)

- For month and year, write **June 1921**, with no comma.
- Abbreviations for months, such as **Feb**, are used only where space is extremely limited. Such abbreviations should use three letters only, and should not be followed by a period (full point) except at the end of a sentence.

Seasons

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Seasons of the year](#)

- Avoid ambiguous references to seasons, which are different in the southern and northern hemispheres.
- Names of seasons may be used when there is a logical connection to the event being described (**the autumn harvest**) or when referring to a phase of a natural yearly cycle (**migration typically starts in mid-spring**). Otherwise, neutral wording is usually preferable (**He was elected in November 1992**, not **He was elected in the fall of 1992**).
- Journals and other publications that are issued seasonally (e.g., "Summer 2005") should be dated as such in citations (*for more information, see [Wikipedia:Citing sources § Seasonal publication dates and differing calendar systems](#)*).

Years and longer periods

Main pages: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Decades](#), [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Centuries and millennia](#), and [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Long periods of time](#)

- Do not use *the year* before the digits (**1995**, not **the year 1995**), unless the meaning would otherwise be unclear.
- Decades are written in the format **the 1980s**, with no apostrophe. Use the two-digit form ('80s) only with an established social or cultural meaning. Avoid forms such as **the 1700s** that could refer to ten or a hundred years.
- Years are denoted by AD and BC or, equivalently, CE and BCE. Use only one system within an article, and do not change from one system to the other without good reason. The abbreviations are written without periods, and with a non-breaking space, as in **5 BC**. Omit AD or CE unless omitting it would cause ambiguity.

More information on all the above topics can be found at [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Chronological items](#), including the handling of dates expressed in different calendars, and times corresponding to different time zones.

Current

*Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Statements likely to become outdated](#)
See also: [Wikipedia:As of](#) and [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Words to watch § Relative time references](#)*

Terms such as "current", "now", and "recent"^[m] should be avoided. What is current today may not be tomorrow; situations change over time. Instead, use date- and time-specific text. To help keep information updated use {{As of}}}, which will allow editors to catalog and update dated statements.

Incorrect: **He is the current ambassador to ...**

Correct: **As of March 2011, he is the ambassador to ...**

Numbers and measurements

Numbers

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Numbers](#)

- Integers from zero to nine are spelled out in words. Integers greater than nine *expressible in one or two words* may be expressed either in numerals or in words. Other numbers are given in numerals or in forms such as **21 million**. See [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Numbers as figures or words](#).
- In general, in numbers with five or more digits to the left of the decimal point, use commas to group those digits. Numbers with four digits are at the editor's discretion: **12,345**, but either **1,000** or **1000**. See [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Grouping of digits](#).
- In general, use decimals rather than fractions for measurements, but fractions are sometimes used with [imperial](#) and [US customary](#) units. Keep articles internally consistent.
- [Scientific notation](#) (e.g., **5.8 × 10⁷ kg**) is preferred in scientific contexts. Markup: `{{val|5.8|e=7|u=kg}}`.
- Write out "million" and "billion" on the first use. After that, unspaced "M" can be used for millions and "bn" for billions: **70M** and **25bn**. See [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Numbers as figures or words](#) for similar words.
- Write **3%**, **three percent**, or **three per cent**, but not **3 %** (with a space) or **three %**. "Percent" is American usage, and "per cent" is British usage (see [§ National varieties of English](#)). In ranges of percentages written with an en dash, write only a single percent sign: **3–14%**.
- Indicate uncertainties as e.g., **(1.534 ± 0.35) × 10²³ m**. Markup: `{{val|1.534|0.35|e=23|u=m}}`. See [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Uncertainty and rounding](#) for other formats.

Currencies

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Currencies and monetary values](#)

- Use the full abbreviation on first use (**US\$** for the US dollar and **A\$** for the Australian dollar), *unless the currency is already clear from context*. For example, the government of the United States always spends money in American dollars, and never in Canadian or Australian dollars.
- Use only one symbol with ranges, as in **\$250–300**.
- In articles that are not specific to a country, express amounts of money in [United States dollars](#), [euros](#), or [pounds sterling](#). Do not link the names or symbols of currencies that are commonly known to English-speakers (**\$**, **€**, **£**), unless there is a particular reason to do so; do not use potentially ambiguous currency symbols, unless the meaning is clear in the context.
- In country-specific articles, use the currency of the country. On first occurrence, consider including conversion to US dollars, euros, or pounds sterling, at a rate appropriate to the context. For example, **Since 2001 the grant has been 10,000,000 Swedish kronor (€1.0M as of August 2009)**. Wording such as "approx." is not appropriate for simple rounding-off of the converted amount.
- Generally, use the full name of a currency, and link it on its first appearance if English-speakers are likely to be unfamiliar with it (**52 [Nepalese rupees](#)**); subsequent occurrences can use the currency sign (just **88 Rs**).
- Most currency symbols are placed *before* the number, and unspaced (**\$123** not **\$ 123**).

Units of measurement

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Units of measurement](#)

- The main unit in which a quantity is expressed should generally be an SI unit or non-SI unit officially accepted for use with the SI. However,
 - Scientific articles may also use specialist units appropriate for the branch of science in question.
 - In non-scientific articles with strong ties to the United States, the main unit is generally a US customary unit (22 pounds (10 kg)).
 - In non-scientific articles with strong ties to the United Kingdom, although the main unit is generally a metric unit (10 kilograms (22 lb)), imperial units are still used as the main units in some contexts (7 miles (11 km) by road).
- Where English-speaking countries use different units for the same measurement, provide a conversion in parentheses. Examples: the Mississippi River is 2,320 miles (3,734 km) long; the Murray River is 2,375 kilometres (1,476 mi) long. See `{{convert}}`.
- In a direct quotation, always retain the source's units. Any conversion should follow in square brackets (or, an obscure use of units can be explained in the article text or a footnote).
- Where space is limited (such as tables, infoboxes, parenthetical notes, and mathematical formulas) unit symbols are preferred. In prose, unit names should be given in full if used only a few times but symbols may be used when a unit (especially one with a long name) is used repeatedly after spelling out the first use (e.g., Up to 15 kilograms of filler is used for a batch of 250 kg), except for unit names that are hardly ever spelled out (°C rather than degrees Celsius).
- Most unit names are not capitalized (see § National varieties of English for spelling differences).
- Use "per" when writing out a unit, rather than a slash: metre per second, not metre/second.
- Units unfamiliar to general readers should be presented as a name–symbol pair on first use, linking the unit name (Energies were originally 2.3 megaelectronvolts (MeV), but were eventually 6 MeV).
- For ranges, see § Number ranges and Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers §§ Date ranges, Percentages, Unit names and symbols, and Formatting of monetary values.
- Unit symbols are preceded by figures, not by spelled-out numbers. Values and unit symbols are separated by a non-breaking space. For example, 5 min. The percent sign and units of degrees, minutes, and seconds for angles and coordinates are unspaced.

Common mathematical symbols

See also: *Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Mathematics* and *Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Common mathematical symbols*

- For a negative sign or subtraction operator, use a minus sign (−, Unicode character U+2212 MINUS SIGN). Input by clicking on it in the insert box beneath the edit window or by typing `−`.
- For multiplication, use a multiplication sign (U+00D7 × MULTIPLICATION SIGN) or a dot (U+22C5 · DOT OPERATOR), which are input by clicking on them in the edit toolbox under the edit window or by entering `×` or `⋅`. Care should be taken not to confuse the dot operator (in the "Math and logic" section of the edit toolbox) with an interpunct (in the "Insert" section of the edit toolbox) or a bullet. The letter x should not be used to indicate multiplication, but it is used (unspaced) as the substitute for "by" in terms such as 4x4.
- Exponentiation is indicated by a superscript, *aⁿ* (typed as `' ' a ' ' <sup> ' ' n ' ' </sup>`).

- Do not use programming language notation outside computer program text. In most programming languages, subtraction, multiplication, and exponentiation are represented by the hyphen-minus `-`, the asterisk `*`, and either the caret `^` or the double asterisk `**` respectively; scientific notation is replaced by E notation.
- Symbols for binary operators and relations are usually spaced on both sides:
 - plus, minus, and plus-or-minus (as binary operators): `+`, `-`, `±` (as in `5 - 3`);
 - multiplication and division: `×`, `÷`;
 - equals, does not equal, equals approximately: `=`, `≠`, `≈`;
 - is less than, is less than or equal to, is greater than, is greater than or equal to: `<`, `≤`, `>`, `≥`.
- Symbols for unary operators are closed-up to their operand:
 - positive, negative, and positive-or-negative signs: `+`, `-`, `±` (as in `-3`);
 - other unary operators, such as the exclamation mark as a factorial sign (as in `5!`).
- Variables are italicized, but digits and punctuation are not; only `x` and `y` are italicized in `2(5x + y)2`.
- `{\math}` can be used to style formulas to distinguish them from surrounding text. For single variables, `{\mvar}` is handy.

Grammar and usage

Possessives

For the apostrophe character, see § [Apostrophes](#). For a thorough treatment of the English possessive, see [Apostrophe](#). For details of how to link possessive constructions, see [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Linking § Possessive links](#).

Singular nouns

For the possessive of singular nouns, including proper names and words ending in `s`, add `'s` ([her niece's wedding](#), [Cortez's men](#), [the boss's office](#), [the US's partners](#), [Descartes's philosophy](#), [Verreaux's eagle](#)). Exception: abstract nouns ending with an `/s/` sound when followed by the word *sake* ([for goodness' sake](#)). If a name ending in `s` or `z` would be difficult to pronounce with `'s` added, consider rewording ([Jesus's teachings](#) becomes [the teachings of Jesus](#)).

Plural nouns

For a normal plural noun ending with a pronounced `s`, form the possessive by adding just an apostrophe ([my sons' wives](#), [my nieces' toys](#)). For a plural noun *not* ending with a pronounced `s`, add `'s` ([women's careers](#), [people's habits](#), [mice's whiskers](#); [The two Dumas's careers were controversial](#), but where rewording is an option, this may be better: [The career of each Dumas was controversial](#)).

Official names

Official names (of companies, organizations, or places) should not be altered. ([St Thomas' Hospital](#) should therefore *not* be rendered as [St Thomas's Hospital](#) or [St. Thomas Hospital](#), even for consistency.)

Usage

A possessive construction must immediately be followed by what is possessed. For example:

- [Richard Nixon's dog Checkers](#), not [Richard Nixon's \(1913–1994\) dog Checkers](#)
- [Albert Einstein's theory](#), not [Albert Einstein's \(pictured\) theory](#)
- [Senator James G. Blaine's ambition](#), not [Senator James G. Blaine's \(R-Maine\) ambition](#)

Pronouns

See also: [Wikipedia:Writing better articles § Use of pronouns](#)

First-person pronouns

To maintain an objective and impersonal encyclopedic voice, an article should never refer to its editors or readers using *I*, *my*, *we*, *us*, *our*, or similar words: [We note that some believe that bats are bugs](#). But some of these words are acceptable in certain figurative uses. For example:

- In historical articles to mean the modern world as a whole: [Only portions of *De re publica* have come down to us](#).
- The [author's we](#) in scientific writing ([We construct *S* as follows](#)), though [passive voice](#) may be preferable ([S is constructed as follows](#)).^[aa]

Second-person pronouns

"WP:YOU" redirects here. For the essay, see [Wikipedia:Wikipedia is not about YOU](#). For the help page, see [Wikipedia:A picture of you](#).

Avoid addressing the reader using *you* or *your*, which sets an inappropriate tone (see also [§ Instructional and presumptuous language](#)).

- Use a noun or a third-person pronoun: instead of [When you move past "Go", you collect \\$200](#), use [A player passing "Go" collects \\$200](#), or [When a player passes "Go", they collect \\$200](#).
- If a person cannot be specified, or when implying "anyone" as a subject, the impersonal pronoun *one* may be used: [a sense that one is being watched](#). Other constructions may be preferable if the pronoun *one* seems stilted: [a person's sense of being watched](#).
- The [passive voice](#) may sometimes be used instead.^[aa] [Impurities are removed before bottling](#).
- Do not bait links, e.g., ["Click here for more information"](#); let the browser's normal highlighting invite a click. ("[Click here](#)" also makes no sense to someone reading on paper.)
- Likewise, "See: ..." or "Consider ..." (in reference to arguments, principles, facts, etc.) are milder second-person baits, common in academic writing ([pedagogy](#)). This interactive personality is inconsistent with an encyclopedia's passive presentation of objective matter.

- "See" and the like can be used to internally cross-reference other Wikipedia material. Do not italicize words like "see". Such a cross-reference should be parenthetical, so the article text stands alone if the parenthetical is removed. {{Crossref}} can be used for this: {{Crossref|(see [[Chicken]])}}, {{Crossref|(See [[Dacian language]] for details.)}} It is usually better to rewrite the material to integrate these links contextually rather than use explicit Wikipedia self-references.
- Do not address the reader with the Socratic method by asking and answering questions.
Did Bacon write Shakespeare? Then who wrote Bacon?

Third-person pronouns

Refer to a person with pronouns (and other gendered words) that reflect their latest self-identification in recent reliable sources. Singular *they/them/their* are appropriate in reference to anyone who uses those, as replacements for neopronouns, and in generic reference to persons of unknown gender. *(For considerably more detail, see WP:Manual of Style/Biography § Gender identity.)*

Ships (military or private-sector) may be referred to by either neuter pronouns (*it*, *its*) or feminine pronouns (*she*, *her*). Both usages are acceptable, but each article should be internally consistent and exclusively employ only one style.^[ab] As with all optional styles, articles should not be changed from one style to another without clear and substantial reason.^[ac] Try to avoid close, successive uses of the same referent for a ship, by using different referents in rotation; for example, *it* or *she*, *the ship*, and the ship's name. The *she/her* optional style does not apply to other vessel/vehicle types, such as trains.^[ad]

(For singular it or plural they in reference to organizations, see § Plurals.)

Plurals

See also: English plurals and Collective noun

For the article title guideline, see Wikipedia:Naming conventions (plurals).

Words adopted into English take the plurals shown in appropriate English dictionaries, otherwise we follow the pluralization conventions of the native language.

Some collective nouns – such as *team* (and proper names of them), *army*, *company*, *crowd*, *fleet*, *government*, *majority*, *mess*, *number*, *pack*, and *party* – may refer either to a single entity or to the members that compose it. In British English, such words are sometimes treated as singular, but more often treated as plural, according to context (but singular is not actually *incorrect*). In North American English, these words are almost invariably treated as singular; the major exception is that when a sports team is referred to by its short name, plural verbs are commonly used, e.g. **the Heat are playing the Lakers tonight**.

Names of towns and countries usually take singular verbs (even when grammatically plural: **the United States is in North America, the Netherlands is also known as Holland**), but exceptionally in British English, typically when used to refer to a sports team named after a town or country or when discussing actions of a government, plural is used. For example, in **England are playing Germany tomorrow**, *England* refers to a football team; but in **England is in the Northern hemisphere**, it refers to the country. See also § National varieties of English including § Opportunities for commonality.

Verb tense

"MOS:PRESENT" redirects here. For the guideline on words such as "currently", "soon", and "recently", see [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Statements likely to become outdated](#).

See also: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Biography § Tense](#), [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Words to watch § Relative time references](#), and [Wikipedia:Writing better articles § Tense in fiction](#)

By default, write articles in the present tense, including those covering works of fiction (see [Wikipedia:Writing better articles § Tense in fiction](#)) and products or works that have been discontinued. Generally, use past tense only for past events and for subjects that are dead or no longer meaningfully exist, such as deceased people or defunct companies. Use past tense for articles about periodicals no longer produced, with common-sense exceptions.

- The PDP-10 is a mainframe computer family manufactured by Digital Equipment Corporation from 1966 into the 1980s.
- *Earth: Final Conflict* is a Canadian science fiction television series that ran for five seasons between October 6, 1997, and May 20, 2002.
- The Gordon Riots of 1780 were several days of rioting in London motivated by anti-Catholic sentiment.
- The Beatles were an English rock band that formed in Liverpool in 1960.
- Barack Obama is a former president of the United States (not **Barack Obama was a president of the United States**).
- *Jumbo Comics* was an adventure anthology comic book published by Fiction House from 1938 to 1953.
- *A Prairie Home Companion* is a radio show that aired live from 1974 to 2016 (not **A Prairie Home Companion was a radio show**).
- *Flappy Bird* is a mobile game developed by Vietnamese video game artist and programmer Dong Nguyen (not **Flappy Bird was a mobile game**).

Tense can be used to distinguish between current and former status of a subject: **Dún Aonghasa is the ruin of a prehistoric Irish cliff fort. Its original shape was presumably oval or D-shaped, but parts of the cliff and fort have since collapsed into the sea.**

Always use present tense for verbs that describe genres, types, and classes, even if the subject of the description (e.g. program, library, device) no longer exists, is discontinued, is unsupported or is unmaintained. Present tense is also used for discontinued television shows.

Vocabulary

Contractions

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Abbreviations § Contractions](#)

Avoid contractions, which have little place in formal writing. For example, write **do not** instead of **don't**. Use of **o'clock** is an exception. Contracted titles such as **Dr.** and **St** generally should not be used but may apply in some contexts (e.g., quoted material, place names, titles of works).

Gender-neutral language

"MOS:GENDER" redirects here. For pronoun usage for individuals whose gender might be questioned, see [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Biography § Gender identity](#).

For an essay with suggestions and sample usage, see [Wikipedia:Gender-neutral language](#). For an essay about not assuming the pronouns of other editors, see [Wikipedia:Editors' pronouns](#).

See also: [Wikipedia:Writing about women](#)

Use [gender-neutral language](#) – avoiding the generic *he*, for example – if this can be done with clarity and precision. This does not apply to direct quotations or the titles of works (*The Ascent of Man*), which should not be altered, or to wording about one-gender contexts, such as an all-female school ([When any student breaks that rule, she loses privileges](#)).

References to space programs, past, present and future, should use gender-neutral phrasing: [human spaceflight](#), [robotic probe](#), [astronaut](#), [cosmonaut](#), [uncrewed mission](#), [crewed spacecraft](#), [piloted](#), [unpiloted](#), not [manned](#) or [unmanned](#). Direct quotations and proper nouns that use gendered words should not be changed, like [Manned Maneuvering Unit](#).

Contested vocabulary

Avoid words and phrases that give the impression of straining for formality, that are unnecessarily regional, or that are not widely accepted. See also [§ Identity](#).

Instructional and presumptuous language

"MOS:NOTE" redirects here. For other uses, see [MOS:NOTE \(disambiguation\)](#).

See also: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Words to watch § Editorializing](#), [Wikipedia:Writing better articles § Information style and tone](#), [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Self-references to avoid § Note that ...](#), and [Wikipedia:It should be noted](#)

Avoid phrases such as [remember that](#) and [note that](#), which address readers directly in an [unencyclopediaic tone](#) and lean toward [instructional](#). They are a subtle form of [Wikipedia self-reference](#), "breaking the [fourth wall](#)". Similarly, phrases such as [of course](#), [naturally](#), [obviously](#), [clearly](#), and [actually](#) make presumptions about readers' knowledge, may [express a viewpoint](#), and may call into question the reason for including the information in the first place.

Do not *tell* readers that something is interesting, ironic, surprising, unexpected, amusing, curious, coincidental, etc. Simply present sourced facts neutrally and let readers draw their own conclusions. Such constructions can usually just be deleted, leaving behind proper sentences with a more academic and less pushy tone: [Note that this was naturally subject to controversy in more conservative newspapers](#). becomes [This was subject to controversy in more conservative newspapers](#). Similar variants which indirectly instruct readers, such as [It should be noted that](#) or [It is important to note that](#), may be rewritten by leaving out those words: [It is important to note that the colloquial dialect of Portuñol is similar to but different from Mirandese](#) becomes just [The colloquial dialect of Portuñol is similar to but different from Mirandese](#).

Avoid rhetorical questions, especially in headings. Use a heading of [Active listening](#) and text such as [The term active listening, coined in ...](#), not [What is active listening?](#)

For issues in the use of [cross-references](#) – e.g., ([see also \[Bulverism\]\(#\)](#)) – see [§ Second-person pronouns](#).

Subset terms

See also: [Wikipedia:Please clarify](#) and [Wikipedia:Vagueness](#)

A *subset term* identifies a set of members of a larger class. Common subset terms are *including*, *among*, and *etc.* Avoid redundant subset terms (e.g., mis-constructions like **Among the most well-known members of the fraternity are included two members of the Onassis family** or **The elements in stars include hydrogen, helium, etc.**). The word *including* does not introduce a complete list; instead, use *consisting of*, or *composed of*.

Identity

See also: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Biography § Child named for parent or predecessor](#), [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Biography § Sexuality](#), and [Wikipedia:Verifiability § Self-published or questionable sources as sources on themselves](#)

When there is a discrepancy between the term most commonly used by reliable sources for a person or group and the term that person or group uses for themselves, use the term that is most commonly used by recent^[m] reliable sources. If it is unclear which is most used, use the term that the person or group uses.

Disputes over how to refer to a person or group are addressed by Wikipedia [content policies](#), such as those on [verifiability](#), and [neutral point of view](#) (and [article titles](#) when the term appears in the title of an article).

Use specific terminology. For example, it is often more appropriate for people or things from Ethiopia (a country in Africa) to be described as *Ethiopian*, not carelessly (with the risk of [stereotyping](#)) as *African*.

Gender identity

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Biography § Gender identity](#)

[Specific guidelines](#) apply to any person whose gender might be questioned, and any living transgender or non-binary person. In summary:

- Use gendered words only if they reflect the person's latest self-identification as reported in recent sources.
- If the person is living and was not notable yet when a former name was in use, that name should not be included in any Wikipedia page, even in quotations, as a privacy matter. Exception: Any name that appears in a source citation (whether as an author or mentioned in a work title) must be included exactly as it appeared in the source. Do not expunge or replace such names.
- Former names under which a living person was notable should be introduced with "born" or "formerly" in the lead sentence of their main biographical article. Name and gender matters should be explained at first appearance in that article, without overemphasis. In articles on works or other activities of such a person, use their current name by default, and give another name associated with that context in a parenthetical or footnote, only if they were notable under that name. In other articles, do not go into detail about such a person's name or gender except when directly relevant to the context.
- Avoid confusing constructions by rewriting. Paraphrase, elide, or use square brackets to replace portions of quotations as needed to avoid confusion, former names, and mismatching gendered words.

For examples and finer points, see [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Biography § Gender identity](#).

Non-English terms

See also: *WP:Manual of Style/Accessibility § Other languages*, *WP:Manual of Style/Lead section § Other languages*, *Category:Wikipedia Manual of Style (regional)*, and *Help:Interlanguage links*

Terms without common usage in English

Main page: *Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Text formatting § Non-English-language terms*

Non-English terms should be used sparingly. In general, use *italics* for phrases and words that are not current in English. This is best done with the {{lang}} template using the appropriate *ISO language code*, e.g., {{lang|es|casa}}. There are alternatives to the {{lang}} template which also provide additional information about a non-English word or phrase, such as a link to the language name; see *Category:Wikipedia multilingual support templates*. As Wikipedia does not apply italics to names of people, places, or organizations, the alternative template {{langr}} can be used to apply the language markup without italicizing.^[ae] Templates like {{lang}} automatically italicize text written using the Latin alphabet, so specifying italics is unnecessary.

Text written in non-Latin scripts such as Greek, Cyrillic, and Chinese should not be italicized or put in bold, as the difference in script is already sufficient to visually distinguish the text. Generally, any non-Latin text should be accompanied by an appropriate romanization.

Terms with common usage in English

Loanwords and borrowed phrases that have common usage in English – **Gestapo**, **samurai**, **vice versa** – do not require italics. A rule of thumb is to not italicize words that appear unitalicized in major general-purpose English dictionaries.

Spelling and romanization

See also: *Wikipedia:Naming conventions (use English-language sources) § Modified letters*, *Wikipedia:Romanization*, and *Category:Romanization*

Names and terms originally written using a non-Latin script—such as the *Greek alphabet*, the *Cyrillic alphabet*, or *Chinese characters*—must be *romanized* for English-language use. If a particular romanization of the subject's name is *most common* in English (**Tchaikovsky**, **Chiang Kai-shek**), that form should be used. Otherwise, the romanization of names should adhere to a particular widely used system for the language in question (**Aleksandr Tymoczko**, **Wang Yanhong**).

The use of *diacritics* in non-English words is neither encouraged nor discouraged. Use generally depends on whether they appear in reliable English-language sources, though with some additional constraints imposed by site guidelines. Provide *redirects* from alternative forms that include or exclude diacritics.

Proper names in languages written using the *Latin alphabet* can include letters with diacritics, *ligatures*, and other characters that are not commonly used in contemporary English. Wikipedia normally retains these special characters, except where there is a well-established English spelling that replaces them with English standard letters. Examples:

- The name of the article on Hungarian mathematician Paul Erdős is spelt with the *double acute accent*, and the alternative spellings *Paul Erdos* and *Paul Erdös* redirect to that article.
- However, the region of Spain named *Aragón* in Spanish and *Aragó* in Catalan is given as *Aragon*, without the accent, as this is the established English name. Non-English forms with

diacritics appear in the article's lead section.

Use of diacritics is determined on a topic-by-topic basis; a small group of editors cannot prohibit or require the use of diacritics within a given class of articles.^[af]

Spell a name consistently in the title and the text of an article. (*Relevant policy: Wikipedia:Article titles; see also Wikipedia:Naming conventions (use English-language sources).*) For a non-English name, phrase, or word, adopt the spelling most commonly used in English-language reliable sources, including but not limited to those already cited in the article.^[ag] For punctuation of compounded forms, see relevant guidelines in § Punctuation.

Proper names in non-English languages should generally not be italicized, unless another reason applies; such as with titles of major published works, e.g., *Les Liaisons dangereuses*; or when being compared to other names for the same subject in a words-as-words manner, e.g., **Nuremberg** (**German: Nürnberg**). When non-English text should not be italicized, it can still be properly tagged by using the `{{lang}}` template with the `|italic=unset` parameter: `{{lang|de|Nürnberg|italic=unset}}`.

Sometimes usage will be influenced by other guidelines, such as § National varieties of English, which may lead to different choices in different articles.

Ligatures

"WP:Æ" redirects here. For other uses, see Wikipedia:AE (disambiguation).

See also: Wikipedia:Naming conventions (use English-language sources) § Modified letters

Ligatures should be used in languages in which they are standard (hence *Moreau's last words were **clin d'œil*** is preferable to *Moreau's last words were **clin d'oeil***) but not in English (*encyclopedia* or *encyclopaedia*, not *encyclo

æ

dia*), except in proper names (*Æthelstan*, not *Aethelstan*). For example, the name of the article on the Nordic god *Ægir* is so spelt, with redirects from the ligature-free form *Aegir* and the Swedish spelling *Ägir*.

Other non-English concerns

- For non-English vernacular names of species, see § Animals, plants, and other organisms.
- For handling of quotations in languages other than English, see § Non-English quotations.
- For non-English characters that resemble single quotation marks and apostrophes, see § Apostrophes.
- For actual non-English quotation characters, see § Quotation characters.
- For the capitalization in the titles of non-English language works, see Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Titles of works § Translations.
- For linear and interlinear glosses and their particular uses of small-caps (and italics and single quotes), see Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters § All caps and small caps.

Technical language

"WP:JARGON" redirects here. For an explanation of jargon used on Wikipedia, see Wikipedia:Glossary.

See also: Wikipedia:What Wikipedia is not § Wikipedia is not a manual, guidebook, textbook, or scientific journal

Some topics are necessarily technical; however, editors should seek to write articles accessible to the greatest possible number of readers. Minimize the use of jargon, and adequately explain its meaning when it is used. Overly technical material can be tagged with `{{Technical}}` or `{{Technical statement}}`, so that it can be addressed by other editors. For topics that require a more technical approach, the creation of a separate introductory article (like Introduction to general relativity) may be a solution.

Excessive *wikilinking* (linking within Wikipedia) can result from trying too hard to avoid putting explanations in parenthetical statements, like the one that appeared earlier in this sentence. Do not introduce specialized words solely to teach them to the reader when more widely understood alternatives will do.

When the concepts underlying the jargon used in an article are too complex to explain concisely in a parenthetical, write one level down. For example, consider adding a brief background section with `{{main}}` tags pointing to articles with a fuller treatment of the prerequisite material. This approach is practical only when the prerequisite concepts are central to the exposition of the article's main topic and when such prerequisites are not too numerous. Short articles, such as *stubs*, generally do not have such sections.

For italicization and other markup of introduced terms, see: Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Text formatting § Words as words.

Geographical items

See also: Wikipedia:Naming conventions (geographic names) and Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Abbreviations § Special considerations

"MOS:GEO" redirects here. For the guideline on linking comma-separated geographical names, see Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Linking § Geographic places. For geographical coordinates, see Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Geographical coordinates.

Geographical or **place names** are the nouns used to refer to specific places and geographic features. These names often give rise to conflict, because the same places are called different things by different peoples speaking different languages. Many place names have a historical context that should be preserved, but common sense should prevail. There can be few places that have not been parts of more than one culture or have had only one name. As proper nouns, all such place names (but not terms for types of places) have major words capitalized.

A place should generally be referred to consistently by the same name as in the title of its article (*see Wikipedia:Naming conventions (geographic names)*). An exception may be made when there is a widely accepted historical English name appropriate to the given context. In cases where such a historical name is used, it should be followed by the modern^[m] name in round brackets (parentheses) on the first occurrence of the name in applicable sections of the article. As with linking, this should not be done to the detriment of style. On the other hand, it is probably better to provide such a variant too often than too rarely. If more than one historical name is applicable for a given context, the other names should be added after the modern English name, that is: "<historical name> (<modern name>, <other historical names>)".

This is an English-language encyclopedia, so established English names are preferred if they exist, and spellings in non-English alphabets should always be transcribed into the Roman alphabet. In general, other articles should refer to places by the names which are used in the articles on those places, according

to the rules described at [Wikipedia:Naming conventions \(geographic names\)](#). If a different name is appropriate in a given historical or other context, then that may be used instead, although it is normal to follow the first occurrence of such a name with the standard modern name in parentheses.

At the start of an article, provide notable equivalent names from other languages, including transcriptions where necessary:

Cologne (German: *Köln*, IPA: [kœln]) is the ...

Mount Fuji (富士山, *Fujisan*; IPA: [ɸud͡ʑisan]) is the ...

Names in languages with no particular present-day or historical ties to the place in question (English excepted, of course) should *not* be listed as alternatives.

Avoid anachronism. An article about [Junípero Serra](#) should say he lived in [Alta Mexico](#), not in [California](#), because the latter entity did not yet exist in Serra's time. The Romans invaded [Gaul](#), not [France](#), and [Thabo Mbeki](#) was the president of the [Republic of South Africa](#), not of the [Cape Colony](#). For clarity, consider also mentioning the current name of the area (for example, "in what is now France"), especially if no English name exists for that area in the relevant historical period.

Media files

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Images](#)

See also: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Accessibility § Images](#), [Wikipedia:Image use policy](#), [Wikipedia:Videos](#), [Help:Creation and usage of media files](#), and [Help:Picture tutorial](#)

- Each media file (image, video, or audio) should be inside the level 2 section to which it relates or at the top of the lead section. Do not place files immediately above section headings.
- Avoid sandwiching text horizontally between two files that face each other, between a file and an infobox, or similar configuration.
- It is often preferable to place images of people so they face the text of the article. Do not achieve this by reversing the image, as this can create a false presentation e.g., by reversing the location of scars or other features.
- Any galleries should comply with [Wikipedia:Image use policy § Image galleries](#). Consider [linking to additional files on Commons](#) instead.
- Do not refer to files as being to the left, the right, above, or below, because image placement varies with platform and is meaningless to people using screen readers; instead, use captions to identify images.
- A file's `|alt=` text takes the file's place for those who are unable to see it. See [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Accessibility/Alternative text for images](#).

Using images to display text

See also: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Accessibility § Text](#)

Any important textual information in an image should also be provided somewhere as text, usually in the image's caption or [alt text](#). Images consisting mostly or entirely of text should be avoided: text in images cannot be easily searched, selected or copied by readers or changed by editors. Images are slower to download and generally cannot be searched or processed by [screen readers](#) used by the visually impaired.

For entering textual information as audio, see [Wikipedia:WikiProject Spoken Wikipedia](#).

Captions

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Captions](#)

Media files should have captions, unless they are unambiguous depictions of the subject of the article or are "self-captioning" (such as reproductions of album or book covers). In biography articles, a caption is not necessary for a portrait of the subject pictured alone, but one might be used to give the year, the subject's age or name, or other circumstances of the portrait.

- Captions normally start with a capital letter.^[f]
- Most captions are not complete sentences but merely sentence fragments which should not end with a period. However, if any complete sentence occurs in a caption, then every sentence and every sentence fragment in that caption should end with a period.
- The text of captions should not be specially formatted, except in ways that would apply if it occurred in the main text (e.g., italics for the Latin name of a species).
- Captions should be succinct; more information can be included on its description page or in the main text. However, captions for technical charts and diagrams may need to be substantially longer than usual; they should fully describe all elements of the image and indicate its significance.

Bulleted and numbered lists

Main pages: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Lists](#) and [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Embedded lists](#)

Further information: [Help:List](#)

- Do not use lists if a passage is read easily as plain paragraphs.
- Use proper wiki markup- or template-based list code. (See [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Lists](#) and [Help:List](#).)
- Do not leave blank lines between items in a bulleted or numbered list unless there is a reason to do so, since this causes the wiki software to interpret each item as beginning a new list.
- Use numbers rather than bullets only if:
 - a need arises to refer to the elements by number;
 - the sequence of the items is critical; or
 - the numbering has some independent meaning, for example in a listing of musical tracks.
- Use the same grammatical form for all elements in a list, and do not mix sentences and sentence fragments as elements, for example when the elements are:
 - **complete sentences** – each one is formatted with sentence case (its first letter is capitalized) and a final period (full point);
 - **sentence fragments** – the list is typically introduced by an introductory fragment ending with a colon;
 - **other elements** – they are formatted consistently in either sentence case or lowercase.

Links

Wikilinks

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Linking](#)

See also: [Help:Link](#)

- **Make links only where they are relevant and helpful in the context:** Excessive use of hyperlinks can be distracting and may slow the reader down. Redundant links (like the one in [the tallest people on Earth](#)) clutter the page and make future maintenance harder. High-value links that are worth pursuing should stand out clearly.
- **Linking to sections:** A hash sign (#) followed by the appropriate heading will lead to a relevant part of a page. For example, [[Apostrophe#Use in non-English names]] links to a particular section of the article [Apostrophe](#).
- **Initial capitalization:** Wikipedia's [MediaWiki](#) software does not require that wikilinks begin with an upper-case character. Capitalize the first letter only where this is naturally called for, or when specifically referring to the linked article by its name (see also related rule for [italics in cross-references](#)): [Snakes are often venomous, but lizards only rarely \(see *Poison*\)](#).
- **Check links:** Ensure the destination is the intended one; many dictionary words lead to disambiguation pages and not to complete or well-chosen articles.

External links

Main page: [Wikipedia:External links](#)

External links should not normally be used in the body of an article. Instead, articles can include an *External links* section at the end, pointing to further information outside Wikipedia as distinct from citing sources. The standard format is a primary heading, == External links ==, followed by a bulleted list of links. Identify the link and briefly indicate its relevance to the article. For example:

- * [<https://history.nih.gov/exhibits/history/index.html>] History of NIH
- * [<https://nih.gov/>] National Institutes of Health homepage

These will appear as:

- [History of NIH \(https://history.nih.gov/exhibits/history/index.html\)](https://history.nih.gov/exhibits/history/index.html)
- [National Institutes of Health homepage \(https://nih.gov/\)](https://nih.gov/)

Where appropriate, use [external link templates](#) such as {{Official website}} and {{URL}}.

Add external links with discretion; Wikipedia is [not a link repository](#).

Miscellaneous

Keep markup simple

Further information: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Accessibility § Best practice: wiki markup and CSS classes](#)

Other things being equal, keep markup simple. This makes wikitext easier to understand and edit, and the results seen by the reader more predictable. Use HTML and CSS markup sparingly. See: [KISS principle](#).

In general, wikitext formatting is considered easier to use than HTML and wikitext is preferred if there are equivalents; see [Help:HTML in wikitext](#). [Obsolete elements and attributes](#) should be updated or removed. There are many templates that allow HTML markup to be used without putting it in articles directly, such as `{{em}}` and `{{strong}}` (see [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Text formatting §§ Emphasis and Boldface](#)).

An [HTML character entity](#) is sometimes better than the equivalent Unicode character, which may be difficult to identify in edit mode; for example, `Α` is explicit whereas `A` (the upper-case form of Greek α) may be misidentified as the Latin A.

Formatting issues

See also: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Text formatting](#)

Modifications in font size, blank space, and color (*see § [Color coding](#)*) are an issue for the Wikipedia site-wide [style sheet](#) and should be reserved for special cases only.

Typically, the use of custom font styles:

- reduces consistency, as the text no longer looks uniform;
- reduces usability, as it may be impossible for people with custom style sheets (e.g. for accessibility reasons) to override it, and may clash with a different [skin](#) or inconvenience people with color blindness (*see below*); and
- causes disputes, as other editors may disagree aesthetically with the choice of style.

Specify font sizes *relatively* (for example with `font-size: 85%`) rather than *absolutely* (like `font-size: 8pt`). The resulting font size of any text should not drop below 85% of the page's default font size.

Color coding

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Accessibility § Color](#)

Do not use color *alone* to mark differences in text: they may be invisible to people with [color blindness](#) and useless in black-and-white printouts or displays.

Choose colors such as **maroon** and **teal** that are distinguishable by readers with the most common form of colorblindness, and *additionally* mark the differences with change of font or some other means (**maroon and alternative font face**, **teal**). Avoid low contrast between text and background colors. See also [color coding](#).

Even for readers with unimpaired color vision, excessive background shading of table entries impedes readability and recognition of Wikilinks. Background color should be used only as a *supplementary* visual cue and should be subtle (consider using lighter, less-dominant [pastel](#) hues) rather than glaring.

Indentation

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Accessibility § Indentation](#)

Do not use quotation templates to indent non-quotations. Various templates are available for indentation, including `{{block indent}}` to indent an entire block and `{{in5}}` to indent inline.

Do not use `:` (description list markup) to indent text in articles, even though it is common on talk pages. It causes accessibility problems and outputs invalid HTML. See [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Accessibility § Indentation](#) for alternatives.

To display a mathematical formula in its own indented paragraph, use `<math display="block">...</math>`. See [Help:Displaying a formula § Block](#) for more details.

To display the equation of a chemical reaction on a separate indented line, follow the guidance at [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Chemistry § Reactions](#).

Controlling line breaks

See also: [Help:Line-break handling](#) and [Template:Spaces](#)

It is sometimes desirable to force a text segment to appear entirely on a single line—that is, to prevent a line break (line wrap) from occurring anywhere within it.

- A **non-breaking space** (or **hard space**) will never be used as a line-break point. Markup: for 19 kg, code `19 kg` or `19{{nbsp}}kg`.
- Or use `{{nowrap}}`, `{{nobreak}}`, or `{{nobr}}` (all equivalent). Markup: for 5° 24′ N, code `{{nobr|5° 24′ N}}`.

It is desirable to prevent line breaks where breaking across lines might be confusing or awkward. For example:

- | | |
|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| ▪ <code>17{{nbsp}}kg</code> | ▪ <code>Boeing{{nbsp}}747</code> |
| ▪ <code>AD{{nbsp}}565</code> | ▪ <code>123{{nbsp}}Elm Street</code> |
| ▪ <code>2:50{{nbsp}}pm</code> | ▪ <code>World War{{nbsp}}II</code> |
| ▪ <code>£11{{nbsp}}billion</code> | ▪ <code>Pope Paul{{nbsp}}VI</code> |
| ▪ <code>May{{nbsp}}2014</code> | ▪ <code>' 'E.{{nbsp}}coli'</code> |
| ▪ <code>{{nobr 5° 24′ 21″ N}}</code> | |

Whether a non-breaking space is appropriate depends on context: whereas it is appropriate to use `12{{nbsp}}MB` in prose, it may be counterproductive in a table (where an unattractive break may be acceptable to conserve precious horizontal space) and unnecessary in a short parameter value in an infobox (where a break would never occur anyway).

A line break may occur at a **thin space** (` `), which is sometimes used to correct too-close placement of adjacent characters. To prevent these, consider using `{{nobr}}` around the expression or `{{thinsp}}` to code the expression.

An undesirable line break may also occur at special characters, such as the forward slash in *bit/s*. To prevent these, consider using `{{nobr}}` e.g., `{{nobr|100 Mbit/s}}`.

Insert non-breaking and thin spaces as named character reference (` ` or ` `), or as templates that generate these (`{{nbsp}}`, `{{thinsp}}`), and never by entering them directly into the edit window from the keyboard – they are visually indistinguishable from regular spaces, and later editors will be unable to see what they are. Inside wikilinks, a construction such as `[[World War II]]` works but `[[World War{{nbsp}}II]]` doesn't.

Scrolling lists and collapsible content

"WP:COLLAPSE" redirects here. For the guideline on collapsing off-topic talk page discussions, see [WP:Talk page guidelines § Off-topic posts](#).

See also: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Accessibility § Users with limited CSS or JavaScript support](#)

Elements that can selectively display or hide content can interfere with the ability of readers to access said content. These mechanisms include scrolling lists, and templates like `{{collapse}}` that can be toggled between collapsed and uncollapsed states using a [hide / show] button. These mechanisms should not be used to conceal "spoiler" information. Templates should generally not be used to store relevant article text, as it interferes with editors' ability to find and edit it. Moreover, content in an article should *not* be collapsed by default. This applies equally to content in footnotes, tables, and embedded lists, image galleries, and image captions.

If such mechanisms are used, care must be taken to ensure the content remains accessible for all users, including those with limited CSS or JavaScript support. When collapsing is desired, it must be done using the `collapsible` parameter of relevant templates, or certain manually added CSS classes (see [Help:Collapsing](#)). Other methods of hiding content should not be used, as they may render content inaccessible to many users, such as those browsing Wikipedia with [JavaScript](#) disabled or using proxy services.

Collapsed or auto-collapsing *cells* or *sections* may be used with tables if they simply repeat information covered in the main text (or are purely supplementary, e.g., several past years of statistics in collapsed tables for comparison with a table of uncollapsed current stats). Auto-collapsing is often a feature of navboxes. A few infoboxes also use pre-collapsed sections for infrequently accessed details. If information in a list, infobox, or other non-navigational content seems extraneous or trivial enough to inspire pre-collapsing it, consider raising a discussion on the article (or template) talk page about whether it should be included at all. If the information is important and the concern is article density or length, consider dividing the article into more sections, integrating unnecessarily list-formatted information into the article prose, or splitting the article.

Invisible comments

"WP:COMMENT" redirects here. For other uses, see [WP:Comment \(disambiguation\)](#).

For invisible control characters, see [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Text formatting § Private Use Area and invisible formatting characters](#).

Main page: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Hidden text](#)

Editors use "invisible" comments – not shown in the rendered page seen by readers of the article, but visible when an editor opens the article for editing – to communicate with one another.

Invisible comments are useful for alerting other editors to issues such as common mistakes that regularly occur in the article, a section title being the target of an incoming link, or pointing to a discussion that established a consensus relating to the article. They should not be used to instruct other editors not to

perform certain edits, as this could be perceived as expressing a form of ownership over an article. However, where existing local consensus is against making an edit, invisible comments may help draw an editor's attention to that consensus.

Do not add too many invisible comments, as they can clutter the wiki source for other editors. Ensure that your invisible comment does not change the formatting, for example by introducing unwanted white space in the rendered page.

How to add an invisible comment

Manually you can enclose the text you intend to be read only by editors between `<!--` and `-->`. For example:

- `<!-- If you change this section title, also change the links to it on the pages ... -->` (there are bots which can do this, see MOS:RENAMESECTION, preferably `{{subst:anchor}}` should be used to prevent this problem.)
- `<!-- When adding table entries, remember to update the total given in the text. -->`

The VisualEditor toolbar (not the source editor toolbar) can also be used:

- Click the "Insert" dropdown **+** **∨**
- Select  "Invisible comment". (You may have to press **∨** "More").

This will produce `<!-- Invisible comment -->`, or if text is selected it will nest the text between `<!--` and `-->`.

Pronunciation

Main page: Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Pronunciation

Pronunciation in Wikipedia is indicated in the International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA). In most situations, for ease of understanding by the majority of readers and across variants of the language, quite broad IPA transcriptions are best for English pronunciations. See Help:IPA/English and Help:IPA (general) for keys, and `{{IPA}}` for templates that link to these keys. For English pronunciations, pronunciation respellings may be used *in addition to* the IPA.

See also

- Editing policy – explains Wikipedia's general philosophy of editing
- Wikipedia is not a manual, guidebook, textbook, or scientific journal – we write for a general, not technical, readership as much as we can
- Introduction to the Manual of Style – a quick introduction to the style guide for articles
- Manual of Style quiz – test your Manual of Style knowledge
- Styletips – a list of advice for editors on writing style and formatting
- Manual of Style Contents – guidelines for film, novels, biographies, military history, etc.
- Identifying and using style guides – an essay providing a summary of off-site style guides' influences on MoS and their uses as sources in Wikipedia articles

Guidance

- [Annotated article](#) – is a well-constructed sample article, with annotations
- [Article development](#) – lists the ways in which you can help an article grow
 - [Basic copyediting](#) – gives helpful advice on copy-editing
 - [Better articles](#) – guidance on how to make articles better
 - [Perfect article](#) – point-by-point guidance on what makes a great article
- [Avoiding common mistakes](#) – gives a list of common mistakes and how to avoid them
- [Be bold](#) – suggests a bold attitude toward page updates
- [Citing sources](#) – explains process and standards for citing references
- [Editing](#) – is a short primer on editing pages
- [Style guide](#) – contains links to the style guides of some magazines and newspapers
- [Wiki markup](#) – explains the codes and resources available for editing a page
- [Wikipedia:*in* versus *of*](#) – proper use of *in* and *of* (or some alternatives, as *from* and *on*)

Tools

- [User:GregU's dashes script](#) – a script that will fix dashes in articles in accordance with [§ Dashes](#)
- [User:Ohconfucius MOSDATE script](#) – a script that will unify dates in articles in accordance with [§ Dates, months, and years](#)

Other community standards

- [List of policies](#) – a comprehensive, descriptive directory of policies
- [List of guidelines](#) – a comprehensive descriptive directory of guidelines
 - [Community standards and advice](#) – a quick directory of community norms and related guidance essays
- [Advice pages](#) – about advice pages written by WikiProjects

Guidelines within the Manual of Style

For the major parts of the Manual of Style, see the sidebar at [top of this page](#).

Names

Proper names:

- Generally: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters](#)
- Peoples and languages that share the same name: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters § Peoples and their languages](#)
- Place names: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Capital letters § Place names](#)
- Diacritical marks in names: [§ Spelling and romanization](#)
- Names of ships in article titles and in the body of articles: [Wikipedia:Naming conventions \(ships\)](#)

Naming and identifying individuals and peoples:

- Generally: [§ Identity](#)
- Specifically (for individuals): [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Biographies § Names](#)
- Opening paragraph of biographies: [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Biographies § Opening paragraph](#)

Names of organizations:

- Generally (has application beyond the topic guideline in which it is currently located): [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Cue sports § Respect for official organization names](#)
- Names that are also trademarks (dedicated MOS page): [Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Trademarks](#)

Names of animal and plant species, etc. (in article titles): [Wikipedia:Naming conventions \(fauna\)](#), [Wikipedia:Naming conventions \(flora\)](#)

Notes

- Though provisions related to [accessibility](#) apply across the entire project, not just to articles.
- This is a matter of policy at [Wikipedia:Consensus § Level of consensus](#): "Consensus among a limited group of editors, at one place and time, cannot override [community consensus](#) on a wider scale. For instance, unless they can convince the broader community that such action is right, participants in a WikiProject cannot decide that a Wikipedia policy or guideline does not apply to articles within its scope." And: "Wikipedia has a higher standard of participation and consensus for changes to policies and guidelines than to other types of pages." Subordinate pages include [MoS detail pages](#), [style essays](#), and the [Simplified Manual of Style](#).
- These matters have been addressed in rulings of the [Arbitration Committee](#) in [2005](#), [2006](#), [2009](#), and [2015](#).
- For the origin of this phrasing, see [ArbCom](#) decisions in [June 2005](#), [November 2005](#), and [2006](#).
- See [2017 ArbCom decision](#), and [Wikipedia:AutoWikiBrowser § Rules of use](#); bot-like editing that continues despite objections or that introduces errors may lead to a [block](#) and to revocation of privileges regarding semi-automated tools.
- Wikipedia uses [sentence case](#) for sentences, article titles, section titles, table headers, image captions, list entries (in most cases), and entries in infoboxes and similar templates, among other things. Any MoS guidance about the start of a sentence applies to items using sentence case.
- Phrases such as [In early life](#) are acceptable (though not required) as section headings. They are also used frequently as part of longer article titles such as [Piracy in the Caribbean](#), especially when a shorter construction (Caribbean piracy) may have ambiguity issues.
- Straight quotation marks and apostrophes are easier to type reliably on most platforms, so this allows for easier redirect targeting. Curly quotations and apostrophes are therefore largely deprecated on English Wikipedia. See also [MOS:CURLY](#) and [MOS:’](#).
- For example in [section anchors](#), [{{subst:Anchor}}](#) should be used to substitute the template instead of [{{Anchor}}](#) which would transclude it. Transclusing [{{Anchor}}](#) in particular additionally causes [other technical and accessibility issues](#).
- A comment outside the `==` `==` but on the same line may cause the section-editing link to fail to appear at all; in other browsers, it may appear, but using it will cause the section heading to not automatically be added to the edit summary.

- k. See <https://phabricator.wikimedia.org/T381786> for an explanation; the comment can cause the editor to choose the wrong section for editing.
- l. To find out how many inbound links there are to the old section title and what articles have them, you can execute [this advanced search](https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?search=all%3A+linksto%3A%22ARTICLE%22+insource%3A%2F%5B%5B%7C%5DARTICLE%5C%23OLDSECTION%2F+&title=Special:Search&profile=all&fulltext=1) (<https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?search=all%3A+linksto%3A%22ARTICLE%22+insource%3A%2F%5B%5B%7C%5DARTICLE%5C%23OLDSECTION%2F+&title=Special:Search&profile=all&fulltext=1>), changing `ARTICLE` to the name of the article, and `OLDSECTION` to the old section title. That advanced search does not search [redirects](#), so also check the article's [Special:WhatLinksHere](#) page for redirects to the old section title. If there are only a small number of links to the old section title, it may be better to just update them manually.
- m. In MoS's own wording, "recent", "current", "modern", and "contemporary" in reference to sources and usage should usually be interpreted as referring to reliable material published within the last forty years or so. In the consideration of name changes of persons and organizations, focus on sources from the last few years. For broader English-language usage matters, about forty years is typical. While style guides with fewer than five years in print have not been in publication long enough to have had as much real-world impact as those from around 2000–2015 (on which MoS is primarily based), the corpora used for [Google ngrams](#) are updated through 2022, and we frequently [rely on](#) what they indicate from the late 20th century and onward.
- n. There are some rare additional exceptions to capitalization of eponyms, in which a term has been strongly conventionalized in lower-case, i.e., is preferred that way in a majority of major English-language dictionaries. For example, [parkinsonian](#) describes a patient exhibiting symptoms of [Parkinson's disease](#). Linguistics/orthography use of the terms [latinize](#), [romanize](#), and [anglicize](#) are increasingly lower-case, and [italic\[s\]](#) in typography always is.
- o. Breeds guideline added per a December 2018 RfC (https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=&diff=prev&oldid=881140543#RfC_on_capitalization_of_the_names_of_standardized_breeds). "Standardized breed" lacks a perfectly clear meaning, but does encompass any breed subject to the [breed standard](#) or [studbook](#) of a notable breeder/fancier organization. Various other groupings of domesticated animals are not standardized breeds: ancient historical varieties, breed groups, feral populations, landraces, and crossbreeds or hybrids that no major organizations recognize as breeds. Many often are not [notable](#) anyway.
- p. `{{Sic}}` should not be used between `<ref> . . . </ref>` tags, or within [citation templates](#) such as [Citation Style 1](#) and [Citation Style 2](#), because it includes markup that will pollute the COinS metadata they produce; see [Wikipedia:COinS](#).
- q. "Quoted text" for typographic conformity and many other purposes includes titles of works, names of organizations, and other strings that are, in essence, quoted. Example: things like "Mexican-American War" are routinely corrected to "Mexican–American War" on Wikipedia, including in titles of cited sources, whether in article prose, citation footnotes, or elsewhere on the page. This has no effect on searching for the works we have cited, since all major search engines disregard punctuation marks.
- r. The translation itself does not require sourcing when done by an editor; however for quotations used in references, [translations by reliable sources are preferred](#), or [better yet English-language sources](#).
- s. Double quotation marks are preferred to single because they are immediately distinguishable from apostrophes:
 - **She wrote that 'Cleanthes' differs from the others', but neither opinion may represent Hume's'** (slows the reader down).
 - **She wrote that "Cleanthes' differs from the others', but neither opinion may represent Hume's"** (clearer).

- t. "Series title italicized" is using *series* to mean the entire show as a whole. A season (also called a *series* in British English) with its own title uses quotation marks for that title, as a sub-work.
- u. This is the principal way in which logical quotation differs from typical British news punctuation practice, in which many publishers permit such a change to the quoted material, which is antithetical to the accuracy purpose of logical punctuation.
- v. Specifically, compound attributives, which are modifiers of a noun that occur within the noun phrase. (See English compound & Hyphenated compound modifiers.)
- w. A change from a general preference for two digits, to a general preference for four digits, on the right side of *year–year* ranges was implemented in July 2016 per this RFC. For more information see Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Dates and numbers § Ranges.
- x. It is not logically possible to have a **12–35 victory**, except in games where a lower score is better. Otherwise, use a construction like **Clovis beat Portales, 35–12**, or **Jameson lost the election, 2345 votes to 6789, to Garcia**, with parties, result, and number order in logical agreement.
- y. The hair space should be done as `{{hair space}}` because the actual Unicode character () is almost invisible, the meaning of the numerical HTML entity (` `) is relatively obscure, and the named HTML entity `" "` is not standard and unsupported in some browsers.
- z. In unusual cases where a lack of spacing could create confusion, such as when a citation is immediately preceded by other superscripted text, a hair space can be inserted between a `<ref> . . . </ref>` tag and the content preceding it.
- aa. The passive voice is considered inappropriate for some forms of writing, but it is widely used in encyclopedia articles, because it avoids inappropriate first- and second-person constructions and tone difficulties. The most common use of encyclopedic passive is to keep the focus on the subject instead of performing a news-style shift to dwelling on a non-notable party. Contrast **The break-in was reported to police the next morning** with **Assistant manager Peggy Plimpton-Chan reported the break-in to police the next morning**.
- ab. As usual, direct quotations should not be altered in such a regard, and have no effect on determination of consistency within Wikipedian-authored content.
- ac. See Wikipedia talk:Manual of Style/Archive (ships as "she") – an index of recurrent debates about this subject, from 2004 through 2022.
- ad. See Wikipedia talk:Manual of Style/Archive 167 § WP:SHE for steam locomotives as well as ships – concluded with a strong consensus against the practice.
- ae. This has the benefit of helping screen readers pronounce the name correctly. Such a proper name may be italicized when contrasting it with a conventional English form: **Munich** (**German: München**).
- af. See the near-unanimous RfC, repeated deletion at Wikipedia:Miscellany for deletion of an anti-diacritics "wikiproject", the policy Wikipedia:Consensus § Levels of consensus, and the Wikipedia:Arbitration Committee's standardized statements of principles on such matters.
- ag. Reputable English-language encyclopedias and dictionaries in the aggregate are often helpful in determining the most widely accepted spelling of a place name, loanwords, etc. It may also help (within limits) to compare search results from the Google Scholar journal index, for topics likely to be covered in peer-reviewed academic papers.

References

1. "T134423 Deprecate nonstandard behavior of self-closed HTML tags in wikitext" (<https://phabricator.wikimedia.org/T134423>). *phabricator.wikimedia.org*. Retrieved 2019-09-25.
2. Ishida, Richard (2015). "Using b and i elements" (<https://www.w3.org/International/question/s/qa-b-and-i-tags>). *W3C Internationalization*. World Wide Web Consortium. Retrieved 1 September 2016. "the content of a b element may not always be bold, and that of an i element may not always be italic."
3. "Hyphens, En Dashes, Em Dashes" (<https://www.chicagomanualofstyle.org/qanda/data/faq/topics/HyphensEnDashesEmDashes/faq0013.html>). *www.chicagomanualofstyle.org*. Chicago Manual of Style. Retrieved 9 March 2022.
4. See [Wikipedia:Categories for discussion/Log/2021 March 20 § MOS:SUFFIXDASH moves](#)

Further reading

Main article: [List of style guides](#)

Wikipedians are encouraged to familiarize themselves with modern editions of other guides to style and usage, which may cover details not included here. Those that have most influenced the Wikipedia Manual of Style are:

- *The Chicago Manual of Style* (University of Chicago Press). The *CMS Crib Sheet* (<https://thecraftycanvas.com/static-resources/library/docs/cmscrib.pdf>) is free online, and summarizes the main provisions.
- *Oxford Guide to Style* (Oxford University Press). A compressed edition is available as *New Hart's Rules*. Available with its companion, the *Oxford Dictionary for Writers and Editors*, in one volume as *New Oxford Style Manual*
- *Scientific Style and Format* (Council of Science Editors)
- *Garner's Modern English Usage* (Oxford University Press)
- *Fowler's Dictionary of Modern English Usage* (Oxford University Press; primarily British English)
- *The MLA Style Manual* (Modern Language Association)
- *The Elements of Style* by Strunk & White

Manual of Style	
Overview · Contents · Tips	
Content	Accessibility · Biography · Disambiguation pages (Organizing by subject area) · Hidden text · Infoboxes · Linking · Self-references · Words to watch
Formatting	Abbreviations · Capitalization · Dates and numbers · Pronunciation · Spelling · Superscripts and subscripts · Text formatting · Titles of works
Images	Captions · Image placement · Icons · Images
Layout	Layout · Lead section · Tables · Trivia sections
Lists	Lists · Lists of works · Road junctions · Stand-alone lists
By topic area	

	Arts	Anime and manga · Comics · Film · Lyrics and poetry · Novels · Television · Video games · Visual arts · Writing about fiction · See also: <i>WikiProject style advice</i>
	Music	Music · Music samples · Record charts · Stringed instruments · See also: <i>WikiProject style advice</i>
	History	Blazons · Military history · See also: <i>WikiProject style advice</i>
	Legal and cultural	Legal · Trademarks · See also: <i>WikiProject style advice</i>
	Regional	Specific naming conventions · Canada · China (and Chinese) · France (and French) · Hawaii · India · Indonesia · Ireland · Japan · Kurdistan · Korea · Pakistan · Philippines · Poland · Singapore · See also: <i>WikiProject style advice</i>
	Religion and education	Islam · Latter Day Saints · See also: <i>WikiProject style advice</i>
	Science and technology	Mathematics · Medicine · Chemistry · Computer science · Taxonomy · See also: <i>WikiProject style advice</i>
	Sports	Cue sports (Snooker) · See also: <i>WikiProject style advice</i>
Related guidelines	Article size · Article titles · Categories, lists, and navigation templates · Categorization · Hatnotes · Subpages · Understandability	
Search		
 Category		
Wikipedia key policies and guidelines (?)		
Five pillars (Ignore all rules)		
Content (?)	 Verifiability · No original research · Neutral point of view · What Wikipedia is not · Biographies of living persons · Copyright (Copyright violations) · Image use · Article titles	
	 Notability · Autobiographies · Citing sources · Reliable sources (Medicine) · Do not include copies of lengthy primary sources · Plagiarism · Do not create hoaxes · Fringe theories · Patent nonsense · External links · Writing articles with large language models (Removal of AI-generated content) · LLM-assisted translation	
Conduct (?)	 Civility · Consensus · Harassment · Vandalism · Ignore all rules · No personal attacks · Ownership of content · Edit warring · Dispute resolution · Sockpuppetry · No legal threats · Child protection · Paid-contribution disclosure	

	G	Assume good faith • Conflict of interest • Disruptive editing • Do not disrupt Wikipedia to illustrate a point • Etiquette • Gaming the system • Please do not bite the newcomers • Courtesy vanishing • Responding to threats of harm • Talk page guidelines (Signatures)
Deletion (?)	P	Deletion policy • Proposed deletion (Biographies) • Speedy deletion • Attack page • Oversight • Revision deletion
Enforcement (?)	P	Administrators • Banning • Blocking • Page protection
Editing (?)	P	Editing policy
	G	Article size (Summary style) • Be bold • Disambiguation • Hatnotes • Broad-concept article • Understandability
		Style Manual of Style (Contents) • Accessibility • Dates and numbers • Images • Layout • Lead section • Linking • Lists
		Classification Categories, lists, and navigation templates • Categorization • Template namespace
Project content (?)	G	Project namespace (WikiProjects) • User pages (User boxes) • Shortcuts • Subpages
WMF (?)	P	Universal Code of Conduct • Terms of Use • List of policies • Friendly space policy • Licensing and copyright • Privacy policy
List of all policies and guidelines (P: List of policies • G: List of guidelines) • Summaries of values and principles		
Writing guides		
Starting an article Getting started		
Layout Visual structure of articles		
The perfect article A checklist of components		
Article development Suggested stages of an article		
Manual of Style Comprehensive style guide		
Writing better articles A collection of advice		

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